

WATER, SEWAGE AND STORMWATER, NEW MASTER PLAN JOINS THE DOTS **P3**



HM SHAH HOLDS REVIEW MEET ON INDIA'S 2030 CWG PREPARATIONS **P5**

'IT'S A ROLE I COULDN'T IGNORE' **P12**



After the flood, another threat looms

Toll rises to 579 | Rescue ops resume at full pace | At least 320 Indians remain missing

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kathmandu, August 28

The death toll from flash floods in central Nepal rose to 579 on Friday, with more bodies recovered as search and rescue operations resume at full pace after a brief slowdown due to fear of fresh floods following an increase in the water level in the Bhotekoshi River area.

The National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) said rising water levels at the site of a devastating flash flood earlier this week increased the risk of another flood in the area.

"The water level mixed with mud has increased at the same place where the flash flood occurred on Wednesday, and there is a risk of more flooding in the area," the NDRRMA said.

The warning came after a massive flash flood swept through Rasuwa and other parts of central Nepal on Wednesday, killing hundreds



FLOOD CRISIS

» The National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority said rising water levels at the site of a devastating flash flood earlier this week increased the risk of another flood in the area

» 'The water level mixed with mud has increased at the same place where the flash flood occurred on Wednesday, and there is a risk of more flooding in the area'

» The Ministry of External Affairs said in New Delhi on Friday that at least 320 Indians remain missing and others are stranded on the Chinese side following devastating flash floods along the Nepal-Tibet border



and causing widespread damage to settlements, roads, bridges and hydro-

power infrastructure. The NDRRMA urged people involved in search

and rescue operations, as well as those staying in the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli

Bihar faces flood threat

Patna: Parts of Bihar faced the threat of a deluge as water levels in the Ganga, Gandak, Kosi and Burhi Gandak rivers showed a rising trend following the devastating flash floods and rains in neighbouring Nepal.

A senior official here said that excess water brought in by the flash floods has caused the Gandak river to swell, forcing authorities to open all 36 gates of a barrage over the river in Valmiki Nagar.

SEE P6

Border trade takes a hit...

Maharajganj/Kushinagar (UP): The Nepal flash floods have disrupted cross-border trade between India and the neighbouring country, with the movement of goods vehicles to Kathmandu and other parts of Nepal via Maharajganj in Uttar Pradesh, affected by damaged and flooded roads.

A queue of around 16 km of cargo vehicles has formed on the Indian side of the Sonauli border in Maharajganj as trucks wait to enter Nepal.

SEE P6

areas for various reasons, to remain highly alert and immediately move to safer places if they face any risk.

Nepal Police on Friday said 579 bodies were recovered from eight districts of the Himalayan nation, with

thousands still missing.

According to the police, 233 dead bodies have been recovered from Chitwan district, 154 from Nawalparasi East, 46 from Gorkha and 40 from Dhading.

CONTINUED ON P4

12 YEARS OF CHANGE

PM lauds Jan Dhan

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28



FILE PHOTO

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has said that the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), which completed 12 years on Friday, has had an unparalleled impact and transformative outcomes.

Launched by Modi as one of his very first programmes on August 28, 2014, the PMJDY has witnessed a transformation in India's financial landscape, and the scheme has become a torchbearer for financial inclusion worldwide. As the world's largest financial inclusion initiative, PMJDY continues to redefine access to banking for all Indians.

The PMJDY ensures that every unbanked adult has access to a basic bank account with no minimum balance requirement and no maintenance charges. Each account comes with a free RuPay debit card, offering an accident insurance cover of Rs 2 lakh, encouraging digital transactions and financial security.

HIGHLIGHTS

» As the world's largest financial inclusion initiative, PMJDY continues to redefine access to banking for all Indians

» The PMJDY ensures that every unbanked adult has access to a basic bank account with no minimum balance requirement and no maintenance charges

Account holders are also eligible for an overdraft facility of up to Rs 10,000, providing a safety net during emergencies.

"Unprecedented scale and transformative outcomes! Jan Dhan Yojana has had an unparalleled impact," Modi wrote on X, referring to a post of MyGov

CONTINUED ON P4

Briefs

L-G, CM celebrate Raksha Bandhan

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor TS Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta celebrated Raksha Bandhan on Friday and greeted people. Gupta celebrated Raksha Bandhan with children living on the streets at the Mukhyamantri Jan Sewa Sadan and interacted with them, listening to their dreams and aspirations.

SEE P3

CNG price hiked by Rs 3.89

NEW DELHI: Compressed natural gas (CNG), widely used in autos, cabs and economy-focused cars, will become costlier by Rs 3.89 per kg from August 29. The new price will be effective from 6 am, Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL) said on Friday night.

MPOST

Trainer held in student murder

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old gym trainer accused of stabbing and strangling a 21-year-old Delhi University (DU) student to death after she decided to end their relationship was arrested following an exchange of fire with police in west Delhi's Rajouri Garden, officials said on Friday. Accused Aqib alias Imran, who has two previous criminal cases against him, including one under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, was apprehended late on Thursday evening after he allegedly fired four rounds at a police team.

SEE P2

Sonia's memoir: A pause & a row

AAISHA SABIR

New Delhi, August 28



THE STATEMENT OF PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE EVOKED A SHARP REACTION FROM SEVERAL CONGRESS LEADERS WHO RAISED ISSUES OF GOVERNMENTAL PRESSURE AND FREEDOM OF EXPRESSION

Alfred A Knopf, an imprint of Penguin Random House, announced that "Belonging" would be released on November 10.

The statement follows a report in the Indian Express claiming that the publisher

Bulandshahr: Bus-dumper collision kills 2, injures 24

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Bulandshahr (UP), August 28

Two people, including a nine-year-old girl, were killed and 24 others injured when a roadways bus collided with a dumper truck here early Friday, police said.

The accident took place around 4.30 am near Shikarpur in the Khurja area when the bus, travelling from Delhi to Kanpur, rammed into the truck moving ahead of it, Additional District Magistrate (Finance and Revenue)

Abhishek Kumar Singh said.

The deceased were identified as nine-year-old Radhika, who was brought to the hospital dead, and Babli, 32, who succumbed to injuries during treatment, he said.

The injured were immediately taken to hospitals for treatment, with some admitted to government facilities and others to private hospitals. Four of the injured were referred to Aligarh for further treatment, the official said.

CONTINUED ON P4

MPOST BUREAU

New Delhi, August 28

Jio Platforms Ltd, the digital services arm of billionaire Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Industries Ltd, has received approval from markets regulator Sebi to proceed with an

initial public offering that could raise about \$3.8 billion, paving the way for what would be the country's largest stock-market listing.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) issued its final observations on August 28,



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with school children and others during Raksha Bandhan celebration at his residence, in New Delhi

PTI

SET TO BE INDIA'S BIGGEST

Jio Platforms gets Sebi nod for \$3.8-billion IPO



according to an update on the regulator's website.

Jio Platforms had filed its draft IPO papers in June.

The company plans to issue up to 27 crore fresh equity shares, equivalent to about 2.9 per cent of its post-issue equity base, according to its draft prospectus. The offering could value Jio Platforms at about

\$137 billion, people familiar with the matter said.

At the estimated issue size of about Rs 37,700 crore (\$3.8 billion), the offering would surpass Hyundai Motor India's \$3.3 billion-equivalent listing in 2024 and become the largest IPO

CONTINUED ON P4

DEAL TO BOOST ARMY FIREPOWER

India to buy US Javelin anti-tank missiles

MPOST BUREAU

New Delhi, August 28

India has sealed a deal with the US to procure Javelin anti-tank guided missile systems to bolster the Indian Army's combat prowess.

US Ambassador Sergio Gor said the agreement reflects a bilateral defence partnership that is growing "deeper, more capable, and more consequential."

It is not immediately known the number of Javelin anti-tank guided missile systems India is procuring or the overall cost of the procurement.



REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

The United States welcomes the Indian Army's signing of a Letter of Offer and Acceptance (LOA) for the purchase of the Javelin anti-tank guided missile

system through the US Foreign Military Sales process, an American readout said.

It said the "milestone" reflects the enduring partnership between the US

and Indian armed forces and opens the door for future collaboration between the US and Indian defence industries.

"The Javelin agreement

demonstrates the depth of US support for the Indian Army and creates new opportunities for our defence industries to work together," Gor said.

CONTINUED ON P4

DEFENCE DEAL

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» It is not immediately known the number of Javelin anti-tank guided missile systems India is procuring or the overall cost of the procurement

» The Javelin system is an advanced, medium-range, fire-and-forget anti-tank guided missile

Saif attack: Accused seeks to plead guilty

MPOST BUREAU

New Delhi, August 28



The Bangladeshi national arrested for allegedly stabbing actor Saif Ali Khan at his residence in Bandra in January 2025 approached a court here on Friday and sought to plead guilty in the case.

Mohammad Shariful Islam, arrested two days after the incident, is currently in judicial custody.

He filed an application expressing his willingness to plead guilty and sought leniency from the court, his lawyer Vipul Dushing said.

The court asked the prosecution to file its reply

and adjourned the hearing to September 11.

Earlier this month, additional sessions judge G P Deshmukh had framed charges against Islam, paving the way for trial.

He was charged under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for 'robbery accompanied by

CONTINUED ON P4

EIGHT INDIAN SIM CARDS SENT TO PAKISTAN

Couple in cop net for running ISI-backed espionage module

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

The Delhi Police has busted an alleged Pakistan ISI-backed espionage module and arrested a couple accused of working for Pakistani intelligence operatives since 2024, procuring Indian SIM cards and sending them to Pakistan through Dubai, an official said on Friday.

Police said Md Sahil (25) and his wife Sameera (21) allegedly provided logistical support to Pakistan-based handlers and recruited people for espionage activities, including reconnaissance of cantonment areas at different locations in India. According to police, the couple came in contact with Pakistani agents through social media in 2024 and were subsequently cultivated to work for the espionage network in return for financial gains. Their Pakistani handlers allegedly paid them Rs 30,000 for the SIM cards, police said.

The Special Cell received information about the alleged network operating in Delhi-NCR and developed the intelligence before identifying its local members. Police said Sahil was arrested first, and forensic analysis of his mobile phone allegedly revealed incriminating conversations with Pakistani intelligence operatives. During interrogation,



SPY NETWORK

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- » Police said Sahil was arrested first, and forensic analysis of his mobile phone allegedly revealed incriminating conversations with Pakistani intelligence operatives
- » Sahil allegedly disclosed that he and Sameera sent eight Indian SIM cards to Pakistan via Dubai during 2024 and 2025
- » Police said Sahil was also assigned another task of recruiting individuals to conduct reconnaissance of cantt areas

Sahil allegedly disclosed that he and Sameera sent eight Indian SIM cards to Pakistan via Dubai during 2024 and 2025. These SIM cards were activated on online messaging applications in Pakistan, and handlers allegedly used them to enter Indian WhatsApp groups to collect sensitive information. Police said the Pakistani operatives also allegedly used

the numbers to approach Indians and collect information.

Police said Sahil was also assigned another task of recruiting individuals to conduct reconnaissance of cantonment areas in different parts of the country. Officials said he was also asked to provide details of Army personnel whose court-martial proceedings were pending before

tribunals. Police said the interrogation of Sahil subsequently led to the arrest of Sameera, who allegedly played a key role in procuring and providing the Indian SIM cards to the Pakistan-based operatives.

Police recovered two mobile phones used in the alleged conspiracy from the accused. Forensic examination of the devices allegedly revealed chats and other incriminating conversations between the couple and their Pakistani handlers, police said.

They said the investigation provided crucial information about the modus operandi of the Pakistan-based handlers and their alleged network of local operatives, including how they used social media and encrypted communication platforms to coordinate espionage activities.

Sahil, who completed his BA from Indira Gandhi National Open University, had worked with a lawyer while planning to pursue an LLB but has been unemployed since June 2025. Sameera, a BA graduate who completed her Class 12 in Delhi, was working at a call centre in Noida before her arrest.

Police said further investigation is underway to identify other members of the alleged espionage network and establish the full extent of the information shared with the Pakistan-based handlers.

Gurugram woman hangs self hours after argument with husband

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gurugram, August 28

A 44-year-old woman allegedly committed suicide by hanging herself at her flat in Gurugram, hours after she had an argument with her husband, police said on Thursday.

The woman, identified as Kirti Mai Mishra, was found hanging in a room of the flat in CHD Avenue Society in Sector 71 on Thursday morning, they said.

According to the police, the woman worked at a real estate company, while her husband, Yuvraj, is an employee of an aviation company.

A preliminary investigation revealed that the couple had an argument on Wednesday night, following which Mishra went into another room, police said.

When she did not come out for a long time on Thursday morning, her husband broke the glass door of the room and looked inside, where he found her hanging, they said.

The man then informed the police, following which a team from the Badshahpur police station reached the spot, took possession of the body and sent it for post-mortem.

“We kept the body in the mortuary and informed the family of the victim. A probe is underway,” Badshahpur SHO Rajesh Kumar said..

DU student murder: Accused gym trainer held after police encounter

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

A 26-year-old gym trainer accused of stabbing and strangling a 21-year-old Delhi University (DU) student to death after she decided to end their relationship was arrested following an exchange of fire with police in west Delhi’s Rajouri Garden, officials said on Friday.

Accused Aqib alias Imran, who has two previous criminal cases against him, including one under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, was apprehended late on Thursday evening after he allegedly fired four rounds at a police team.

The police team fired seven rounds in self-defence, resulting in Imran sustaining three bullet injuries in both legs, the officials said, adding that no police personnel was injured in the exchange of fire.

Imran was rushed to the Guru Gobind Singh Hospital in Raghuraj Nagar for treatment.

The exchange of fire took place around 11:15 pm near the Sub-Registrar Office on Nala Road in Rajouri Garden, after police received specific information about Imran’s movements in the area around 10:55 pm.

“The police team disclosed its identity and repeatedly asked him to surrender. Instead, he suddenly took out a pistol and opened fire towards the police party,” Deputy Commissioner of Police (West) Hareshwar Swami said.



missioner of Police (West) Hareshwar Swami said. Despite repeated warnings, the accused continued firing. Head Constable Jitender fired a warning shot in the air, but Imran did not relent. Jitender and another head constable, Nand Kishore, subsequently fired three rounds each aimed at his legs, police said.

A separate FIR has been registered at the Rajouri Garden police station under the relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Arms Act in connection with the firing incident.

The arrest came after an extensive manhunt was launched following the killing of Muskan Sharma at her residence in west Delhi’s Tilak Nagar on August 26. An FIR under section 103(1) (murder) of the BNS was registered at the Tilak Nagar police station on August 27.

Police said around 15 teams comprising personnel from the Special Staff, AATS, Narcotics Squad, Sub-Division Tilak Nagar crack teams, local police and other specialised units were deployed

“EXCHANGE OF FIRE TOOK PLACE AROUND 11:15 PM NEAR THE SUB-REGISTRAR OFFICE ON NALA ROAD IN RAJOURI GARDEN, AFTER POLICE RECEIVED INFO ABOUT IMRAN’S MOVEMENTS...”

to trace the accused.

CCTV footage showed Imran entering the victim’s house at around 5:45 pm on August 26 and leaving around 6 pm. His subsequent movements were also tracked through the CCTV footage, leading to his identification as the prime accused.

According to the DCP, Sharma was a second-year student in the DU’s School of Open Learning (SOL), a content creator and a part-time model. Her elder sister is also a model. She was the youngest of four siblings and lived with her parents and siblings in a rented house near Mangla Hospital in west Delhi.

Police said Imran had known Muskan for around 18 months after the two met at the gym where he worked as a trainer.

Police said Imran, previously booked for stalking and sexual assault, allegedly killed the woman after she sought to end their relationship, stabbing and strangling her at her Tilak Nagar home following an argument.

He was also accused of harassing her and pursuing her despite her refusal.

Briefs

AIIMS issues guidelines for CRE-5

NEW DELHI: AIIMS New Delhi has issued a brochure for online seat allocation under CRE-5 for Group B and C posts. Provisionally qualified candidates will submit one-time preferences for posts and institutes, with allocation based on merit and choices. After allocation, candidates must report physically with original documents for verification. No waiting list will be maintained.

Two held for robbing Rs 44 lakh

NEW DELHI: Two men, including the son of a businessman who had handed over Rs 44 lakh to a cash courier agent, have been arrested for allegedly hatching a conspiracy to rob the money in Delhi’s Shahdara area, police said on Friday. Jitendra Kumar (52), a resident of Shastri Nagar, had collected Rs 44 lakh from Avd-hesh Tiwari and was supposed to deliver the money to Raj Kumar. Police found that the Rs 44 lakh robbery was allegedly planned by the victim’s son, Prabhay Tiwari, to repay his debts. Tiwari and his associate Sarab Tiwari were arrested, officials said.

Caregiver electrocuted after falling into road cavity in Surajmal Vihar

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

A 28-year-old pedestrian was electrocuted in Surajmal Vihar after a small section of the road near an electricity pole reportedly caved in, trapping him up to his waist and bringing him into contact with a live wire, police said on Friday.

The incident took place on Thursday morning when Sandeep, a caregiver, was returning home after attending to an older person, they said. According to the preliminary enquiry, Sandeep was crossing road number 58 when the unpaved road near an electricity pole on the divider reportedly caved in.

He fell into a nearly three-

“

PROBE POINTS TO ALLEGED NEGLIGENCE BY CIVIC AGENCIES, AND POLICE ARE ALSO EXAMINING CCTV FOOTAGE

foot-deep pit and was trapped up to his waist. Police said an electric current was allegedly passing through the lower portion of the pole, causing Sandeep to suffer an electric shock and die at the spot.

Police received a PCR call regarding the incident around 7:30 am. Following the call, police personnel reached the spot and took Sandeep to a hospital, where doctors declared

him brought dead.

Officials said the body has been sent to GTB Hospital mortuary for a postmortem, and police are awaiting the report.

The investigation points to alleged negligence by civic agencies, and police are also examining CCTV footage from cameras installed around the spot.

Police said Sandeep lived with his aunt in Bihari Colony and worked as a caregiver at a house in Surajmal Vihar. He travelled on foot every day to look after an older adult, they said.

According to local information, workers filled the caved-in section of the road with stones, debris and cement by evening after the incident.

Property dealer nabbed in 2016 cyber fraud case

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE
New Delhi, August 28

The Delhi Police have arrested a 45-year-old property dealer in connection with a 10-year-old cyber fraud case in which a woman was allegedly cheated of Rs 16.08 lakh by persons posing as HDFC Bank employees.

The accused, Sunil Gupta alias Sunil Aggarwal, a resident of Bhagwati Garden, Uttam Nagar, was arrested on August 21 following a tip-off that he was working as a property dealer in the area.

The fraud took place in 2016, when the victim was allegedly duped into shar-

ing confidential banking, ATM and PIN details with callers posing as bank representatives. The accused and his associates subsequently carried out NEFT and IMPS transactions, transferring Rs 16,08,710 from her account. The case was initially registered at Pan Bazar police station in Kamrup, Assam, and later transferred to Dwarka South police station after the money was traced through bank accounts opened using forged identities. Gupta allegedly created fake accounts for fraudsters, while police linked him and associate Mahey to multiple cyber-crime cases.

Head constable carries divyang man to safety

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE
New Delhi, August 28

A Delhi Traffic Police head constable went beyond his duties to help a divyang person safely cross a busy road near Azadpur Mandi in Sarai Pipal Thala, Model Town, on August 27.

Head Constable Manoj, deployed for traffic management, noticed the person waiting for an opportunity to cross amid heavy traffic.

He immediately stepped in, lifted the person and carried him across the road to safety. The gesture reflected the tact, compassion and public-spiritedness expected of traffic personnel, who are tasked not only with managing traffic but also assisting vulnerable road users.

Manoj’s act of kindness embodies the Delhi Traffic Police’s ethos of “Serving with Care and Compassion” and highlights its commitment to citizens’ safety.

Police rescue four people trapped inside burning building

No casualties were reported

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

The Delhi Police rescued four people trapped on the third floor of a building after a fire broke out in Baljeet Nagar, police said on Friday.

After the Patel Nagar police station received a PCR call about the incident on Thursday, they dispatched a police team to the affected house on Hill Marg in Patel Nagar.

“With fire tenders facing difficulties reaching the building due to narrow and congested lanes, police personnel, assisted

by locals, began rescue and fire-control efforts. Water was arranged from nearby terraces and adjoining houses to control the flames and prevent the fire from spreading to neighbouring buildings,” a senior police officer said. Police personnel entered the building and rescued four people, despite heavy smoke and intense billowing flames.

The police team doused the fire.

Police said items kept in the house were destroyed, and no casualties were reported.

Water, sewage and stormwater, new master plan joins the dots

Groundwater recharge planned across multiple urban spaces

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, August 28

Delhi's water infrastructure may no longer be planned as separate systems for supply, sewage and drainage, with MPD-2047 proposing an integrated "urban water cycle" in which the three are treated as interconnected infrastructure. The master plan identifies long-term water security as a major focus and says water supply, wastewater management and stormwater drainage should be treated as interconnected "water-linked infrastructures". It also defines Water Sensitive Urban Design (WSUD) as an approach that brings water supply, wastewater, stormwater and groundwater management into urban planning.

Under the proposed framework, Delhi's future water management would combine conservation, recycling, groundwater recharge and stormwater



MPD 2047 FURTHER PROPOSES GROUNDWATER RECHARGE VIA WATER BODIES, GARDENS, FLY-OVERS, PARKS...

CLOSER LOOK

- » MPD identifies long-term water security as a major focus, says water supply, wastewater mgmt and stormwater drainage should be treated as interconnected 'water-linked infra'
- » It also defines Water Sensitive Urban Design (WSUD) as an approach that brings water supply, wastewater, stormwater and groundwater management into urban planning

management. The plan proposes restricting water requirements in land-pooling areas and LDA developments to 40 gallons per capita per day, while regeneration and transit-oriented development schemes would not receive additional water beyond

prescribed norms.

The plan also proposes maximum reuse of treated wastewater for non-potable purposes, including horticulture, irrigation, road cleaning, firefighting and construction. New drainage networks would be designed to direct

stormwater towards identified groundwater-recharge sites, while measures such as bioswales, rain gardens, vegetated filters and pervious stormwater drains could be adopted.

Experts said such integration could help cities move away from treating water supply, sewage and flooding as isolated problems.

"The concept is sound, but implementation will be difficult because water supply, sewerage, drainage, roads and floodplain management involve different agencies. Unless they work through one coordinated system, the integrated approach could remain largely on paper," said Sanjay Kumar, an Environment activist. The MPD further proposes groundwater recharge through water bodies, parks, gardens, flyovers, city roads and Yamuna flood-basin areas, while calling for GIS-based drainage mapping.

L-G & CM mark Raksha Bandhan with outreach

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, August 28

Delhi Lieutenant Governor TS Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday celebrated Raksha Bandhan and extended greetings to people, with both highlighting the festival's message of affection, trust and togetherness.

Gupta celebrated the festival with children living on the streets at the Mukhyamantri Jan Sewa Sadan, where the children tied rakhis to her wrist. She interacted with them about their education, interests, lives and future goals, and listened to their dreams and aspirations.

According to an official statement, some of the children in the group were admitted to schools on the instructions of officials. Gupta assured the children that the Delhi government would support their education and overall well-being, helping them build a better future.

The Chief Minister emphasised that every child should have the opportunity to dream and



People celebrate 'Raksha Bandhan' festival during an event organised by Krantikari Yuva Sangathan PTI

receive the necessary support to turn those aspirations into reality. She encouraged the children to continue studying and remain focused on their goals, while stressing the importance of providing children from vulnerable backgrounds with dignity, security and access to opportunities.

The interaction was part of the government's outreach to children from disadvantaged backgrounds and underlined the need to ensure that their circumstances do not become a barrier to education and growth.

In a post on X, Gupta said Raksha Bandhan was a sacred festival of affection, trust and duty that reflected the strength of familial values.

She wished that the bond would bring happiness, prosperity and warmth to every home and that the love between brothers and sisters would remain unbreakable.

Sandhu celebrated Raksha Bandhan at Lok Niwas, where women from his security team tied rakhis to him. He said the gesture reflected love, trust, togetherness and community.

Delhi govt plans to construct 61-km road corridor

New Delhi, August 28

To reduce traffic congestion, the Delhi government plans to hire a private consultant to construct an approximately 61-kilometre elevated corridor along the Najafgarh drain, connecting Wazirabad to North Delhi, officials said on Friday.

The government announced the project in February this year. Now the Public Works Department (PWD) plans to hire a consultant to conduct a feasibility study and prepare a project plan.

"The stretch is heavily congested due to a mix of slow-moving vehicles and cross movements during peak and non-peak hours, causing heavy traffic. We plan to hire a consultant to conduct a feasibility study before the project starts," a PWD official said.

As per the plan, roads will be developed from Chhawla to Basaidarpur along both sides of the drain over a length of 27.415 kilometres, totalling 54.83 kilometres across both banks. Further, a 5.94-kilometre two-lane road will be constructed on the left bank from Jhatikra Bridge to Chhawla Bridge.

The Rs 454-crore project will develop a 61-km corridor along the Najafgarh drain, easing congestion, reducing travel time, fuel consumption and emissions, with dedicated cycling, jogging and walking tracks.

Rakhis tied to responsible commuters

New Delhi, August 28

The Delhi Traffic Police on Friday organised a special road safety drive on the occasion of Raksha Bandhan, tying rakhis to responsible road users and urging them to commit to following traffic rules.

The initiative, "Rakhi ka waada, suraksha ka iraada," combined education, enforcement and encouragement to promote traffic discipline across the national capital. "As part of the drive, traffic personnel interacted with commuters at several major intersections and traffic points, including Chintamani traffic light and Seelampur traffic light in Shahdara Circle and Majnu Ka Tila Check Post," a senior police officer said. Personnel appreciated road users who complied with traffic rules, while women police officers tied rakhis to them as a symbolic gesture of safety and protection.

The commuters were encouraged to reciprocate by pledging to continue following traffic regulations.

Commuters were urged to wear helmets, use seat belts, follow traffic rules, maintain lane discipline, avoid mobile phones and refrain from drunk driving.

Anand Vihar: Joint inspection focuses on traffic flow, safety, pollution

New Delhi, August 28

Traffic movement, pedestrian safety and air pollution control measures at Anand Vihar Railway Station and the adjoining NCRTC area came under review on Friday as officials from multiple depart-

ments conducted a joint on-site inspection.

The inspection, carried out in coordination with the East Delhi district administration, covered the entry and exit points of the railway station and surrounding roads. Officials assessed traffic

CONDUCTED UNDER GUIDANCE OF E DELHI DIST MAGISTRATE KARANJIT, DCP TRAFFIC (E) SHWETA SINGH

congestion, pedestrian movement, escalator availability, e-rickshaw operations, access to the park and road dust in the area.

The exercise was con-

ducted under the guidance of East Delhi District Magistrate Karanjit and DCP Traffic (East) Shweta Singh, with officials from concerned departments par-

ticipating in the inspection.

Traffic management emerged as a key focus, with officials examining measures to ensure smoother movement of passengers and vehicles around the railway station. The availability and functioning of escalators were

also reviewed, along with arrangements for pedestrian movement and access to the nearby park.

Officials discussed systematic e-rickshaw movement, traffic regulation, road cleaning, dust suppression and pedestrian management.

City to set up senior citizen centres

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

Delhi's senior citizens will soon have a dedicated space to swap loneliness for ludo, meditation and social gatherings, with the Delhi government set to launch the 'Vayo Anand' scheme aimed at promoting an active and socially engaged life for those aged 60 and above.

Under the scheme, recreational centres will be developed across the capital where senior citizens can meet and interact, participate in indoor and outdoor games, attend yoga and meditation classes and take part in cultural and social activities. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said ensuring dignity, health and social engagement for the elderly remains a priority of her government.

"Senior citizens of Delhi are an invaluable asset to society. Ensuring their dignity, health, active lifestyle and social engagement is

a priority of our government," Gupta said.

The centres will offer facilities including carrom, ludo, televisions, computers, newspapers, magazines, books, seating arrangements, fans and coolers. Yoga and meditation classes will be organised, while activities such as painting, craft, pottery, storytelling, nutritional counselling, health and fitness classes and outdoor tours will also be conducted.

The government plans to organise at least five to six special programmes every year, including celebrations of International Yoga Day, Senior Citizens' Day and national festivals. Monthly medical camps and first-aid kits will also be available at the centres.

According to the scheme, centres will operate at least five days a week for a minimum of seven hours a day, between 7 am and 8 pm. Preference will

be given to ground-floor facilities or buildings with lifts, along with adequate ventilation and toilets. Special programmes will also be organised for women, persons with disabilities and transgender senior citizens.

Eligible recreational centres will receive financial assistance of Rs 2.40 lakh annually, or Rs 20,000 per month, from the government. The assistance will be released in two equal half-yearly instalments.

The centres must have at least 200 members aged 60 years or above and can operate from community spaces, including those run through RWAs, CGHS and chawls.

Gupta said the scheme aims to provide elderly residents with a safe space close to home where they can spend time with their peers, participate in recreational and health activities and stay away from loneliness.

COMMUTERS STUCK IN LONG TRAFFIC SNARLS Raksha Bandhan rush chokes roads

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

Delhi witnessed heavy traffic congestion at several key stretches on Friday as the city saw increased movement on Raksha Bandhan, with long queues of vehicles reported on the Delhi-Meerut Expressway, MB Road, Kalindi Kunj, Pragati Maidan and Akshardham, while the metro also saw a heavy rush of passengers.

The congestion on the Delhi-Meerut Expressway, which began before the festival weekend, continued for several hours, with vehicles moving slowly and traffic teams deployed to regulate movement.

Heavy traffic was also reported on MB Road in the Chhatarpur area, with long queues stretching for



considerable distances. The Lado Sarai Old MB Road traffic signal also witnessed regular congestion, with commuters raising concerns over buses allegedly jumping red lights and obstructing pedestrians at zebra crossings.

Kalindi Kunj remained another major bottleneck, with commuters reporting traffic jams towards the Delhi side and describing

congestion on the stretch as a daily occurrence.

Traffic snarls were also witnessed around Pragati Maidan and the Akshardham stretch, while slow-moving traffic was reported on the Delhi-Saharanpur Highway near Geeta Colony Road amid increased movement ahead of the festival.

The Delhi Traffic Police issued an advisory in view

of Raksha Bandhan celebrations on August 27 and 28, warning of increased pedestrian and vehicular movement around Anand Vihar ISBT, Road No. 56, NH-9 and Vikas Marg.

Commuters have been advised to avoid these stretches wherever possible, plan their journeys in advance and allow additional travel time.

The increased road traffic was accompanied by a rush in the Delhi Metro, with several stations and trains witnessing a heavy influx of passengers as people travelled ahead of the festival.

Traffic personnel and other enforcement teams remained deployed at several congestion-prone points to manage the flow of vehicles and ease snarls.



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Before you make the purchase, make sure you:



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FOR IMMEDIATE POLICE HELP CALL 112

TO SHARE INFORMATION CALL 14547

(DP/991/2026)

Color calibration bars and registration marks.

UGC-NET
results
announced for
84 subjects

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

The results of the UGC National Eligibility Test (NET) for 84 subjects have been announced, with more than 4,000 candidates qualifying for the Junior Research Fellowship, the National Testing Agency said late on Friday.

“Out of 6.07 lakh candidates who appeared for the exam in 84 subjects, over 97,000 have qualified for PhD admissions and over 4,000 for JRF,” a senior NTA official said.

The National Testing Agency (NTA) had ordered fresh examinations for candidates who appeared for the English, Commerce and Sociology papers in June this year after an expert committee found factual, typographical, translation and language-related errors in the question papers.

The NTA released the UGC-NET answer key on August 16, nearly two months after the examination, while issuing a special notice concerning the Sociology, Commerce and English papers.

‘NUMBER OF HIGH-BURDEN DISTRICTS DROPPED’
India sees nearly 80% decline in malaria cases, deaths btwn 2015-25: Health Ministry

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28



KEY POINTS

- » The review focused on the 33 high-burden districts spread across nine states and Union Territories, which accounted for 64 per cent of malaria cases and 54 per cent of malaria deaths reported in 2025
- » The review also highlighted the need to strengthen surveillance systems and improve the quality of malaria data
- » Detailed state-wise reviews were undertaken for Mizoram, Odisha, Tripura, Assam, Andhra Pradesh, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Maharashtra.

for 64 per cent of malaria cases and 54 per cent of malaria deaths reported in 2025.

Detailed state-wise reviews were undertaken for Mizoram, Odisha, Tripura, Assam, Andhra Pradesh, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Chhat-

tisgarh, Jharkhand and Maharashtra.

Reaffirming India’s commitment to achieving the Sustainable Development Goal of eliminating malaria by 2030, Patnaik called for sustained vigilance and area-specific strategies to prevent resurgence and

accelerate elimination.

She stressed effective implementation of District Action Plans in all 33 high-burden districts and Village Action Plans in malaria-prone villages, with interventions tailored to local epidemiological and geographical conditions.

The meeting emphasised strengthening the “Test, Treat and Track” strategy, with delays in diagnosis and treatment identified as key factors behind malaria deaths.

States were advised to intensify active surveillance and ensure uninterrupted availability of diagnostic facilities and anti-malarial drugs, particularly in hard-to-reach and vulnerable areas.

The review also highlighted the need to strengthen surveillance systems and improve the quality of malaria data.

States were asked to examine unusually high Annual Blood Examination Rates (ABER) to identify possible duplicate testing, repeated entries and inclusion of asymptomatic screening. The ministry said asymptom-

atic cases detected through mass screening should be reported separately and excluded from Annual Parasite Incidence (API) and ABER calculations to ensure a more accurate assessment of the malaria situation and programme performance.

Patnaik also underscored the importance of inter-sectoral coordination, noting that health interventions alone cannot address factors such as water-logging, source reduction and environmental management that contribute to malaria transmission.

States were advised to strengthen coordination with Rural Development and Urban Development departments, as well as Panchayati Raj Institutions, for effective implementation of environmental and vector-control measures.

Greater involvement of self-help groups, community volunteers and Panchayati Raj representatives was also encouraged to improve early reporting of fever cases, identify mosquito-breeding sites and water-logging, and support source-reduction activities.

India, Kuwait hold
inaugural key
dialogue in Delhi
To bolster defence cooperation



OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

India and Kuwait on Friday held a key dialogue during which the two sides agreed to bolster bilateral defence cooperation across a wide range of areas, including training, military exercises, industry, and research and development.

The inaugural meeting of the India-Kuwait Joint Defence Committee (JDC) was held in New Delhi.

The first meeting of the JDC marked an important step towards operationalising the objectives outlined in the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on Defence Coop-

eration between the two countries, signed during the visit of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Kuwait in December 2024, the defence ministry said in a statement.

“Both countries agreed to further strengthen bilateral defence cooperation across a wide range of areas, including training, military exercises, military medicine, staff talks, defence industry, and research and development (R&D),” it said.

The meeting was co-chaired by joint secretary in the ministry, Amitabh Prasad and Brigadier General Raed Alsakran of the five-member Kuwaiti delegation.

From page 1

After the flood

Similarly, 37 dead bodies were recovered from Nuwakot, 30 from Tanahu, 27 from Nawalparasi West, and 12 from Rasuwa.

Five people have died in Gyirong County in the Tibet Autonomous Region, according to Chinese authorities.

At least 1924 people, including 86 security personnel, 517 foreign tourists and 127 Nepali travellers, have been missing since Wednesday morning when the flash floods hit Rasuwa and adjoining districts of Nepal.

So far, 1,545 injured and stranded people have been rescued from various affected regions. Among them, 84 are currently undergoing treatment in various hospitals in Kathmandu, where families are desperately searching for their loved ones.

So far, 4451 people have been rescued from different affected areas. These include 129 foreign nationals, including 85 Indians, and 191 people trapped in tunnels of various hydropower projects. Altogether, 101 injured people are undergoing treatment in various hospitals in Kathmandu.

Search and rescue operations continued for the third day of the tragic incident with the mobilisation of 7,451 security personnel, including 2,391 Nepal Army personnel, the police statement said.

Bodies recovered from Rasuwa and Nuwakot have been found as far downstream as Chitwan, Tanahun, Nawalparasi, Gorkha and other districts, with morgues in several areas running out of space.

Meanwhile, the Nepal government has decided to halt all examinations from August 29, given the situation that developed following the devastating natural disaster.

Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah and members of his cabinet have decided in a cabinet meeting to donate a month’s salary to the disaster relief fund.

In another development, Nepal has denied refusing assistance from friendly countries and the international community, saying it wants to “prioritise” maximum deployment of its own security forces, which are familiar with local environmental conditions and rugged terrain.

Speaking to the National

News Agency (RSS), Nepal foreign minister Shisir Khanal said that “International assistance was not rejected but that the rescue strategy was decided based on national capacity, immediate need and Nepal’s unique geographical situation.” Meanwhile, China sounded a Level-IV alert late on Thursday, saying a large barrier lake had formed near the confluence of the Chhochen Khola and Purepu Tsangpo rivers in Nepal. China’s emergency response system for natural disasters has four levels, with Level-I being the highest and Level IV the lowest.

Chinese authorities had informed Nepal that around 2 million cubic metres of water had accumulated in the lake, with another 3 million cubic metres potentially entering it over three days, raising concerns about a possible breach.

The lake had formed near the confluence of the Chhochen Khola and Purepu Tsangpo rivers, which originate in Tibet and flow into Nepal as part of the Bhotekoshi river system.

Meanwhile, the Ministry of External Affairs said in New Delhi on Friday that at least 320 Indians remain missing and 400 others are stranded on the Chinese side following devastating flash floods along the Nepal-Tibet border.

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said 96 Indian nationals who were stranded on the Chinese side have safely crossed over to Nepal by land route.

Twenty-one Indians arrived in New Delhi this afternoon, a day after they reached Kathmandu from the flood-affected areas of Nepal, he said.

The Indian nationals from Tamil Nadu were received at the airport in the national capital by External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar.

“As far as the number of people (Indians) whom we are not able to contact or who are missing, the figure at this point in time is 320,” Jaiswal said.

Sixty-three Indian nationals, working at the Trishuli-One hydropower project, were also rescued, he said.

“There are also around 100 persons of Indian origin who remained uncontactable. These are people of Indian origin who may have gone for Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, but they hold other nationalities,” he said.

Jaiswal said 400 Indians are stranded on the Chinese side but they are safe.

“They have been in touch with their family. Our embassy has been in touch with several of them. Many of their family members also contacted us through the helpline numbers that our embassy is running in Beijing.” “Our embassy is in touch with local authorities in China, and they are working out as to how these people who are there can be evacuated,” he noted.

In a related development, Jaishankar held a high-level meeting with senior officials and reviewed the situation in Nepal with a focus on tracking the status of missing Indians. Indian envoys to Kathmandu and Beijing also joined the meeting through virtual mode.

Alongside the relief supplies, India also sent an 11-member team of doctors and paramedics, as well as a reconnaissance crew to assess tunnel rescue operations.

After return of the 21 Indians, Jaishankar said they were very thankful to the Nepalese Army for rescuing them.

“We have also made a specific offer to the Nepal authorities to dispatch NDRF teams along with their associated equipment that can help in ongoing search and rescue operations and bring relief assistance to people impacted by the tragedy,” MEA spokesperson said.

PM lauds Jan Dhan

India, the government of India’s innovative citizen engagement platform.

MyGov India said in a series of social media posts that there was a time when access to formal banking depended on where someone lives, financial standing or simply how far the person concerned was from a bank.

Today, India’s banking landscape tells a different story, with crores of Jan Dhan accounts, wider rural access, greater participation by women and banking reaching the last mile, it said.

“A bank account is more than a number. It is a financial identity. From 14.7 crore Jan Dhan accounts in 2015 to 59 crore in 2026, India has expanded formal banking access at an unprecedented scale, bringing millions into the financial system and enabling greater participation in the formal economy,” MyGov India said.

Financial inclusion becomes meaningful when

women are part of the journey. Today, nearly 33 crore women hold Jan Dhan accounts, representing 56 per cent of all Jan Dhan account holders. This wider access to formal banking is helping more women participate in the financial system, strengthening household and community-level financial inclusion.

With 46 crore Jan Dhan accounts held across rural and semi-urban India, financial inclusion is reaching communities beyond major cities. These represent 78 per cent of all Jan Dhan accounts, reflecting a banking network reaching deeper across India.

Sonia’s memoir

backed out after Gandhi refused “editorial changes” to the manuscript.

“Penguin Random House India is not the publisher of Belonging in India. Any suggestion that Penguin Random House India decided not to publish Belonging because the author declined editorial changes does not accurately reflect the circumstances,” the company said.

“As a publisher, it is both our prerogative and our responsibility to fact check and provide authors with recommendations that are in the best interests of their books. This is a normal part of the publishing process. Throughout the relevant discussions, Penguin Random House India’s position was that we remained willing and keen to publish the book,” it said.

Even as the status of the book’s distributor in India remains uncertain, a page on e-commerce website Amazon showed an E-book version of “Belonging” up for pre-order at Rs 2,615.

According to the e-commerce website, the e-book is published by William Collins, an imprint of HarperCollins UK. The book’s India release has been a matter of much speculation since Alfred A Knopf’s announcement.

Sonia Gandhi, Rajya Sabha MP and senior Congress leader, remains one of India’s most discussed political figures. She will be sharing her intimate story of marrying into one of India’s most powerful political families, the tragedy of losing Rajiv Gandhi that threw her into the “public world of politics” and turning down prime ministership in 2004 among other things, according to Alfred A Knopf.

Gandhi, 79, who has rarely

shared her private life in public forums, narrates her life, “from her childhood in post-war Italy, to the romance that brings her to India, to the shattering losses that will reshape not only her own future but also that of her adopted home”, it said.

Several Congress leaders lashed out at PRHI, asking what prevented it from publishing the memoir in India when it was being published worldwide by its imprint.

Senior Congress leader and former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot said “pressuring and stopping” the book is akin to “murdering the freedom of expression”.

He claimed that pressure was put on Penguin India “to remove sections on Modi, RSS and those related to the occupation of Indian territory by China during the Modi regime”.

Senior party leader and former Madhya Pradesh chief minister Kamal Nath also said the publisher’s “refusal” to publish the autobiography is a matter of grave concern.

“Will the publisher decide what a senior figure like Mrs. Gandhi will write and what she will not? The question also arises whether the publisher is saying this on its own or if there is pressure from someone on it?” Nath said in his post on X in Hindi.

Congress’ deputy leader in Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi slammed Penguin India’s statement on the issue as “weak”.

“Such a weak statement. Penguin India is more than happy to publish ‘Exam Warriors’ and several books on RSS. No doubt there are those in the BJP government who have now become afraid of a book being being read by the people of India,” Gogoi said on X.

The Indian Youth Congress said, “Dear SOLD Penguin, nobody asked whether you were ‘keen’. Tell us what changes you wanted, and why. The rest is corporate grammar.”

Earlier in June, PRHI had dropped journalist and author Joe Sacco’s graphic novel on Muzaffarnagar riots of 2013 after taking into account “local legal, regulatory, commercial, and market considerations”.

The publisher also made headlines in February this year for saying that it had “not printed” former Army Chief General M M Naravane’s memoirs titled “Four Stars of Destiny”. This was days after

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi flashed a hard copy of the book in Parliament. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Bulandshahr

District Magistrate Kumar Harsh and Senior Superintendent of Police Dinesh Kumar Singh inspected the accident site and took stock of the circumstances leading to the crash. They later visited Kailash Hospital and enquired about the condition of the injured and the treatment being provided to them.

The officials directed the concerned authorities to ensure that all the injured receive proper medical care, the ADM said.

Jio Platforms

in India. A proposed IPO by the National Stock Exchange, estimated at about Rs 30,000 crore, would also be smaller.

The proceeds will be used primarily to repay or prepay, in whole or in part, about Rs 27,500 crore of outstanding borrowings of Reliance Jio Infocomm Ltd, Jio Platforms’ material subsidiary, according to the draft prospectus. The remainder is earmarked for general corporate purposes.

The public offering comes as India’s primary market has remained active, with strong participation from retail investors and domestic institutions. More than two dozen IPOs have been announced or launched since July 1, nearly matching the 28 recorded in the first half of 2026.

Jio Platforms houses Reliance’s digital businesses, including its telecommunications operations.

Reliance Jio Infocomm had more than 53.3 crore subscribers as of June-end, making it the world’s second-largest mobile operator by subscriber count after China Mobile, according to company data.

The business has also expanded into other areas, including cloud, artificial intelligence and enterprise network services. Jio Platforms has previously attracted major global technology and financial investors.

In 2020, Meta invested Rs 43,574 crore for a 9.99 per cent stake, while Google invested Rs 33,737 crore for a 7.73 per cent holding.

Other investors, including Silver Lake, Vista Equity Partners, General Atlantic, KKR, Mubadala, Abu Dhabi Investment Authority, TPG, L Catterton, the Public Investment Fund, Intel Capital and Qual-

comm Ventures collectively invested about Rs 74,745 crore for roughly a 15.2 per cent stake. Reliance Industries owns about 66.4 per cent of Jio Platforms, while Meta and Google together hold about 17.7 per cent, according to the draft prospectus.

The IPO would be the first public offering from the Reliance group since 2008 and the first IPO of a consumer-focused business within the conglomerate.

While Jio Platforms is chaired by Ambani, his eldest son Akash is its managing director. Akash is also the chairman of Reliance Jio Infocomm Ltd, the telecom part of the company. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Saif attack

the use of a deadly weapon’, causing grievous hurt and house trespass as well as relevant sections of the Foreigners Act and Passport (Entry into India) Rules.

Khan was repeatedly stabbed with a knife by an intruder inside his 12th floor apartment in upscale Bandra on January 16, 2025.

The 54-year-old actor underwent an emergency surgery at the Lilavati Hospital and was discharged after five days.

India to buy US Javelin

“We see tremendous potential for future cooperation that strengthens the defence industrial bases of both countries,” he said, according to the readout.

The Javelin system is an advanced, medium-range, fire-and-forget anti-tank guided missile. It is used by the US Army, US Marine Corps, and numerous international customers and is designed for use against a wide array of targets, including armoured vehicles and fortified positions.

The Javelin system is produced by the Javelin Joint Venture, a partnership between RTX and Lockheed Martin.

“The landmark signature further strengthens the US-India Major Defence Partnership by demonstrating the depth of ongoing US support to the Indian Army,” the American readout said.

“It also opens discussions on mutually beneficial co-production and additional opportunities to strengthen the defence industrial bases of both countries,” it said.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

CWC RETURNS TO INDIA AFTER TWO DECADES

HM Shah holds review meet on India's 2030 CWG preparations

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Ahmedabad, August 28

Union Home minister Amit Shah took stock of India's 2030 Commonwealth Games preparations and also discussed the country's 2036 Olympic bid in a review meeting that was also attended by Union Sports minister Mansukh Mandaviya and Gujarat's deputy CM Harsh Sanghavi here.

The meeting took place here on Thursday.

"Modi govt is firmly committed to establishing India as a global sporting destination by hosting international sporting events...chaired a review meeting on India's bid for the 2036 Olympics, as well as preparations for hosting the 2029 Police and Fire Games and the 2030 Commonwealth Games, in Ahmedabad," Shah posted on 'X'.

The Home Ministry will have a critical role in the Games in terms of supervising security arrangements and other logistics.

The Commonwealth Games will be returning to India after two decades and will be held in Ahmedabad. In 2010, Delhi hosted the showpiece for the first time.

Ahmedabad is also in the race to hold the Olympic Games in 2036 and Sanghavi is representing the city in the interactions with the International



Union Home minister Amit Shah celebrates 'Raksha Bandhan' festival with girls who have Type-1 diabetes, in Ahmedabad

PTI

CLOSER LOOK

- » The Home Ministry will have a critical role in the Games in terms of supervising security arrangements and other logistics
- » India is currently in the Continuous Dialogue phase of the host selection process and a decision on the country's bid is not expected before 2029

Olympic Committee as he also holds the sports portfolio.

India is currently in the Continuous Dialogue phase of the host selection process and a decision on the country's bid is not expected before 2029.

The World Police and

Fire Games would be the first major multi-sport international competition in Ahmedabad before all this.

The mega-event is set to feature close to 10,000 athletes from 70 countries.

Meanwhile, Shah celebrated Raksha Band-

han in Ahmedabad with girls from his Gandhinagar Parliamentary constituency who are suffering from Type-1 diabetes, calling attention to the government's initiative of providing free insulin to affected children.

Sharing a post on X, the Home minister said that he spent Raksha Bandhan with daughters from his Gandhinagar constituency who are suffering from Type-1 diabetes. He said that children with the disease need to take insulin shots for the rest of their lives, which can be an expensive burden for the families.

FREE ONLINE COACHING SCHEME

Accountability-evading gimmick: Congress slams govt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 28

The Congress on Friday hit out at Prime Minister Narendra Modi over his announcement of free online coaching for competitive exam aspirants, saying it was an "accountability-evading gimmick" and alleging that the government has shown little capacity to implement such a scheme successfully.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi had raised the issue of the growing coaching industry and its impact on the country's public education system at the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event in Kota, Rajasthan on June 17.

"He had raised one of the most important issues in education today -- that



an extractive coaching industry has supplanted the public education system and that Indian families are now spending 2.5 times more on coaching centres than the government of India invests in education," Ramesh said on X.

"It was this disclosure that forced the Prime Minister -- in a desperate attempt to escape growing public pressure -- to announce free online coaching for

students on 15th August. But his government's track record hardly inspires any confidence," he said.

The existing Free Coaching scheme of the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment has been missing its target for three years, he pointed out.

The ministry was supposed to enrol 10,500 candidates for free coaching over three years, but has enrolled only 2,790 students, or just 26 per cent of the target, Ramesh said.

"The budget for this scheme has been reduced every year and last year's spending was less than half the budget. These startling facts have been revealed in the latest report of the Parliamentary Standing Committee of the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment tabled on August 10, 2026," the Congress leader said.

Akhilesh attacks BJP over inflation, women's safety

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

Etawah, August 28

Samajwadi Party president and former Uttar Pradesh chief minister Akhilesh Yadav on Friday met party workers and people in Safai on the occasion of Raksha Bandhan and launched a sharp attack on the BJP govt at the Centre and in Uttar Pradesh, accusing them of failing to address inflation, women's safety, farmers' concerns and education.

Speaking to the media, Yadav said that if the Samajwadi Party returns to power, women's protection, security, dignity and health would be among its key priorities.

He said the party would take policy decisions aimed at improving the condition of women and ensuring their empowerment with dignity.

PM to visit Uzbekistan, Kyrgyzstan

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, August 28

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will visit Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan from August 29 to September 1, during which he will hold delegation-level talks and attend the 26th SCO Summit.

At the SCO Summit to be held in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, from August 31 to September 1, Modi will highlight India's priorities of security, connectivity and opportunity and

will also hold bilateral meetings with SCO leaders on the sidelines of the summit.

The PM will also attend the opening ceremony of the 6th World Nomad Games in Kyrgyzstan in a celebration of the rich cultural heritage of Central Asia. Modi will be in Uzbekistan on August 29-30 on a bilateral visit, and in Kyrgyzstan for the 26th SCO Summit from August 31 to September 1, the prime minister's office said in a statement.

Prayagraj: Gen Z questions turn into political issues

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

Prayagraj, August 28

Questions raised by Gen Z are increasingly turning into political issues, prompting political parties to reach out to a generation that is emerging as an important vote bank.

While some of these young people will vote for the first time, many others have already stirred public debate over education, employment and competitive examinations.

Prayagraj, which attracts an estimated 1.5 to 2 lakh students and young job aspirants from eastern Uttar Pradesh and neighbouring Bihar, is emerg-

ing as a key testing ground for this new generation of youth politics.

The city's large population of educated and politically aware youngsters has caught the attention of major political parties. The Samajwadi Party was among the first to make a move. Party president Akhilesh Yadav visited Prayagraj on June 29 for a Prabuddh Sammelan, using the programme to gauge the political mood among young people and students.

On August 8, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi interacted directly with students and young people in Prayagraj during the 'Students Ki Goonj' programme.

Prez paves way for High Court bench in Ladakh

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Leh/Jammu, August 28

President Droupadi Murmu has issued a regulation that establishes a bench of the High Court of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh in the Union Territory of Ladakh, paving the way for bringing higher judicial services closer to the people of the region.

The regulation, titled 'The Union Territory of Ladakh (Sitting of the Bench of the High Court of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh in Ladakh) Regulation, 2026,' was promulgated by President Murmu on August 27 and

published in the Gazette of India Extraordinary on the same day.

Issued by the Ministry of Law and Justice, the regulation seeks to establish a high court bench in Ladakh and address related matters, fulfilling a long-standing demand from the people of Ladakh for improved access to higher judicial remedies in the geographically remote area.

Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena welcomed the promulgation, stating that the notification was issued within seven days of the Union Cabinet's decision.



President Droupadi Murmu celebrates 'Raksha Bandhan' festival, in New Delhi

PTI

BEWARE!

ANY PROMISE OF BIG RETURNS MAY ACTUALLY BE A TRAP!!

REMEMBER

- Any scheme offering double or triple of principal amount in a short period could be a trap
- Anyone paying interest rate higher than RBI guidelines can be a fraud
- Invest only in registered NBFC or banks following RBI guidelines
- Transaction must be made by cheque against proper receipt only (Don't accept hand written rough receipt)

CHECK

- The details of Chit Fund Committee being run, its duration, amounts Involved, number of members from the Registrar of Chit Fund
- The registration of Company/Committee and its financial documents [online] from the Registrar of Companies/Chit Fund and other details from its office
- Whether passbooks with relevant entries are being maintained and margin money is being deposited with Registrar Chit Funds,
- The past performance/criminal record of the company and credibility of its management

Terms & conditions of the offer/MOU carefully before making investment

Follow us on: @EowDelhi

Economic Offences Wing, PS Mandir Marg Complex, Mandir Marg, New Delhi-110001 Email ID: dcp-eow-dl@nic.in

E-mail to CP, Delhi at: cpdelhi@delhipolice.gov.in | Write to: Cp, Delhi at P.O. Box No. 171, GPD, New Delhi

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(DP/9912/2026)

RAKSHA BANDHAN AT 14,140 FEET

Women tie rakhis to troops guarding India-China border

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Gangtok, August 28

Raksha Bandhan took a patriotic turn at Sikkim's high-altitude border areas as women from across the country tied rakhis to Army, ITBP and SSB personnel deployed to guard India's frontiers.

According to a press release by event organiser Hemant Yadav Foundation, the festival was celebrated at strategically important locations, including Nathu La Pass on the India-China border at an altitude of 14,140 feet, ITBP Sherathang at around 13,900 feet and SSB headquarters at Ranipool. The initiative brought together 26 young women from six states, along with students from Sikkim University and Harkamaya College of Education.

The women tied rakhis to the personnel and expressed gratitude for their service,



KEY POINTS

- » The initiative brought together 26 young women from six states, along with students from Sikkim University and Harkamaya College of Education
- » The participating women said meeting troops serving in difficult terrain and extreme conditions left them with a deep sense of pride and gratitude

describing the soldiers and security personnel as brothers and protectors of the country.

Foundation founder Hemant Kumar Yadav said Raksha Bandhan was not merely about the bond between siblings

but also embodied love, trust, responsibility, protection and national unity. "Today, from an altitude of 14,140 feet, we are conveying Raksha Bandhan greetings to more than 1.4 billion citizens of India," Yadav said.

The participating women said meeting troops serving in difficult terrain and extreme conditions left them with a deep sense of pride and gratitude.

Yashoda Sharma of Sikkim said witnessing soldiers guarding the country at such a high altitude was both inspiring and humbling, while Priyanka Kaur of Assam said standing with Army personnel so close to the India-China border made her feel that "the entire nation is present here together".

Smriti Rekha Khuntia of Odisha highlighted India's diversity, saying protecting the country's unity and integrity was a collective responsibility. Another participant described the occasion as an opportunity to stand "not merely to celebrate Raksha Bandhan, but to honour those who protect the nation that we call our home."

FOUR BODIES DRIFT INTO INDIAN TERRITORY

Nepal floods: Deluge threat looms over Bihar as several rivers swell

MPOST BUREAU
Patna, August 28

Parts of Bihar faced the threat of a deluge as water levels in the Ganga, Gandak, Kosi and Burhi Gandak rivers showed a rising trend following the devastating flash floods and rains in neighbouring Nepal.

A senior official here said that excess water brought in by the flash floods has caused the Gandak river to swell, forcing authorities to open all 36 gates of a barrage over the river in Valmiki Nagar.

Around 1.02 lakh cusecs of water were released from the Gandak Barrage by 5 pm on Friday.

“Teams of the Water Resources Department at the Gandak barrage are on alert. Officers have been directed to ensure regular inspection of the river embankments, maintain a round-the-clock vigil and make all preparations for a possible emergency,” the official said.

An ice-rock landslide blocked a river near Nepal’s border with China, triggering a flash flood that devastated the Himalayan nation, leaving at least 547 dead.

This, along with incessant rainfall, led to both Uttar Pradesh and Bihar administrations stepping up monitoring of their river systems downstream of the rivers of Nepal.

“The water levels of sev-



A swollen river flows through a flood-affected area in the aftermath of the flash floods, in Dhading, Nepal, Friday

India sends 3rd tranche of aid to Nepal

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 28

India on Friday dispatched a third tranche of 10 tonnes of relief supplies to flood-ravaged Nepal, alongside an 11-member team of doctors and paramedics, as well as a reconnaissance crew to assess tunnel rescue operations.

"A third flight carrying 10 tonnes of humanitarian assistance has departed

for Kathmandu. The assistance includes portable generator sets, dignity kits, food packets and water purification tablets," External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said.

"An 11-member team of doctors, paramedics & Recce team for Tunnel rescue operations is also on-board. India continues to support Nepal's ongoing relief and rescue efforts," he said on social media.

eral rivers, including the Ganga, Gandak, Kosi and Burhi Gandak, have been rising following continuous rainfall in their catchment areas in Nepal.

“The rivers have touched or crossed the

danger level at several places in the bordering districts,” a senior official of the Water Resources Department said.

According to the department’s bulletin on Friday, the Gandak, Kosi, Ganga,

Burhi Gandak and Ghaghra rivers were flowing above the danger mark at many places in the state and had touched warning levels in some places.

The Gandak river has breached the danger mark

in Gopalganj, while the Kosi and Burhi Gandak have touched the danger level in Khagaria, Katihar and Kursela.

The Ganga was flowing above the danger mark at Digha, Hathidah and Gandhighat in Patna and Kahlgaon in Bhagalpur, said the bulletin, adding that the Ghaghra river was flowing above the danger mark in Siwan district’s Darauli.

People in low-lying areas have been shifted to safety, said a senior official. All departments concerned in Bihar have been put on alert.

“District Magistrates have been directed to personally monitor the situation. Flood Control Department officials and engineers are camping at vulnerable sites in Bhagalpur, Purnea, Katihar, West Champaran and other districts,” the official said.

The National Disaster Response Force and State Disaster Response Force have been kept on standby at certain locations.

Meanwhile, four bodies were recovered from a river in Uttar Pradesh’s Maharajganj district after they apparently drifted into Indian territory from Nepal amid the ongoing flood situation, officials said on Friday.

The bodies were found in a severely decomposed state and have not yet been identified.

UP: 16-km truck queue at Sonauli border as floods in Nepal hit trade

Floods also affect residents who work in Nepal

MPOST BUREAU
Maharajganj, August 28

The flash floods in Nepal have disrupted cross-border trade with India, with the movement of goods vehicles to Kathmandu and other parts of the neighbouring country affected by damaged and flooded roads.

A queue of around 16 km of cargo vehicles has formed on the Indian side of the Sonauli border in Uttar Pradesh’s Maharajganj district, as trucks wait to enter Nepal. Besides vehicles headed for Kathmandu, cargo trucks travelling to other parts of Nepal are also facing delays as traffic movement on several routes remains affected.

The queue has stretched towards Nautanwa, raising

OFFICIALS SAID THAT THE SITUATION COULD WORSEN IF ROAD CONNECTIVITY IS NOT RESTORED SOON

concerns over traffic movement on the national highway. Security agencies and police personnel are monitoring the situation and regulating the movement of vehicles. Officials said that the surveillance at the Sonauli border has been intensified, and police station heads in the border areas have been directed to remain alert.

They warned that the situation could worsen if road connectivity in Nepal is not restored soon, potentially delaying the movement and supply of goods between the two coun-

tries. The floods have also affected residents of Maharajganj who work in Nepal.

Raj Kumar Gautam, a resident of Jagarnathpur village, is returning home after escaping the flood-hit situation in Nepal. He had been working as a furniture worker in Kathmandu for nearly a year.

Gautam told his family over the phone that the situation was terrifying, with several families devastated and people struggling to reach safer places amid panic and chaos. His daughter Ankita said she spoke to him around 4 pm on Thursday, when he informed that he was returning home via Bihar.

Gautam is the sole earning member of his family and supports the livelihood and education of his children.

NTA: Centre appoints 2 directors, joint director

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 28

The Centre has appointed two directors and a joint director to the National Testing Agency (NTA), which has been facing flak for issues related to the NEET paper leak.

Ravi Kumar Singh (IPS officer) and Prasanna Venkatesh V, an Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer, have been appointed as directors in the NTA, according to separate orders dated August

27, issued by the personnel ministry.

Amit Samdaryia, a 2016 batch Indian Revenue Service (Customs and Indirect Taxes) officer, has been selected for appointment as joint director in the NTA, an order issued by the personnel ministry said. All three orders referenced a circular from the personnel ministry stating that the appointed officers must assume their new positions within three weeks of the orders’ issuance.

MP: Bus crash leaves at least 5 dead in Rajgarh

MPOST BUREAU
Rajgarh, August 28

Five people were killed and 12 sustained injuries after a speeding sleeper bus crashed into the safety wall of a bridge in Madhya Pradesh’s Rajgarh district on Friday morning, police said.

The accident occurred around 7 am on the Bhopal bypass bridge in Biaora, an official said.

He said that the bus was on its way to Indore from Kanpur, Uttar Pradesh, and it lost control and crashed into the safety wall while negotiating a bend on the bridge.

Police arrived at the scene and shifted the injured to the Civil Hospital in Biaora, from where four critically injured victims were referred to Bhopal for treatment.

Rajgarh Superintendent of Police Amit Tolani said that five people, including a policeman, were killed in the accident, while 12 others, including two women, were injured.

He said the windows shattered due to the impact of the crash, causing passengers in the upper sleeper berths to fall out of the bus.

The deceased include Ravi KP (45), a police inspector from Bengaluru; Vikas Shukla (29), a bus driver from Fatehpur, Uttar Pradesh; Belal Ali (23) of Gopalganj, Bihar; Guddu Kushwaha from Sitapur, Uttar Pradesh; and Jyotiraditya Singh from Vijayawada.

Prima facie, the bus’s overspeeding appears to have caused the accident, the official added.

Briefs

CBI arrests IRS officer

NEW DELHI: The CBI has arrested 2009-batch IRS officer Vinay Kumar Kantheti, serving as additional commissioner CGST in Maharashtra’s Raigad, CGST superintendent Rakesh Kumar Sinha and a private person in an alleged Rs 1.5-crore bribery case. The demand was allegedly negotiated down to Rs 40 lakh. The private person was caught accepting the amount.

Myanmar woman held with gold...

AIZAWL: A 41-year-old woman from Myanmar was arrested in Aizawl with a gold biscuit worth Rs 13 lakh, an official said on Friday. The arrest was made in a joint operation by the Assam Rifles and Mizoram Police in Zungtui in the northern outskirts.

Security stepped up in Parel

MUMBAI: Security was tightened in central Mumbai’s Parel area on Thursday after two communities clashed following an Eid procession the previous night, police said. The confrontation reportedly began with slogan-shouting and escalated into an altercation and minor stone-pelting. Police used force to disperse the mob and are scanning CCTV to identify those involved.

TREE PROTECTION DAY Bihar CM ties Raksha Sutra to tree in Patna



MPOST BUREAU
Patna, August 28

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Friday tied a Raksha Sutra to a tree at Rajdhani Vatika-1 here, marking Raksha Bandhan and Tree Protection Day. He, on the occasion, also planted a Nagalingam sapling.

The state-level Tree Protection Day programme was organised by the Environment, Forest and Climate Change Department with the aim of creating awareness among people

about the environment, encouraging protection of plants and promoting tree plantation on a larger scale.

Environment, Forest and Climate Change minister Ramchandra Prasad, Additional Chief Secretary of the department Anand Kishore, Chief Minister’s Secretary Sanjay Kumar Singh, Special Secretary of the department Alok Kumar and Principal Chief Conservator of Forests Arvinder Singh were among those present at the programme.

CISF & DFI join hands to boost drone capabilities

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

The CISF has signed an MoU with the Drone Federation of India (DFI) to strengthen drone and counter-drone capabilities at critical installations.

The agreement aims to develop CISF Recruit Training Centre, Behror, as a Centre of Excellence for drone and counter-drone systems. CISF safeguards over 370 units, while more than 3,000 personnel have been trained in drone and anti-drone operations and around 80 units have been equipped with the technology. The organisations will develop SOPs, conduct joint exercises and red-teaming, and undertake training, drone forensics and applied research.

CISF DG Praveer Ranjan said the partnership would help create a realistic test environment against evolving threats.

Nayab Saini says Punjab wants change, Mann hits back at BJP

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, August 28

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and his Punjab counterpart Bhagwant Singh Mann traded sharp political barbs at separate events at Baba Bakala Sahib in Amritsar on Friday, with both leaders highlighting their governments’ welfare initiatives and attacking their political opponents.

Addressing a BJP Mahasammelan, Saini claimed that people in Punjab were “fed up” with the Aam Aadmi Party government and were looking for a change. He accused the AAP dispensation of pushing the state into corruption and alleged that it had surpassed the previous Congress government in this regard. Saini said Punjab needed a government focused on development, good governance, transparency and public welfare, asserting that the BJP would form the next



SAINI AND MANN TRADED SHARP POLITICAL BARBS

government in the state under Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s leadership.

He contrasted the BJP-ruled Haryana with Punjab, citing more than two lakh government jobs provided in Haryana on merit without “parchi-khar-chi”. He also highlighted schemes including LPG cylinders at Rs 500 for eligible women, the Lado Lakshmi Yojana, procurement of farmers’ entire produce at MSP, free dialysis and construction of more than 1.60

lakh houses.

Meanwhile, Mann marked Rakhri Punia at Baba Bakala Sahib by announcing the transfer of Rs 181.50 crore as three months’ ‘Sanman Rashi’ to 5.30 lakh women under the Mukh Mantri Mawan-Dheeyan Satkar Yojna. He said the scheme had so far benefited 70.92 lakh women and that the government was working to cover one crore women.

Mann also targeted the BJP, Akali Dal and Congress, accusing them of misleading people and pursuing political interests. He rejected the possibility of a BJP return to power in Punjab and alleged that the party had treated the state and its farmers unfairly.

Defending his government’s record, Mann said more than 90 per cent of households were receiving free electricity, while 70,840 youngsters had secured government jobs. He said canal water had reached 1,587 villages.

Cheers to Made in UP: Liquor exports soar as global mkts open up

State’s liquor shipments rise 84.5% year-on-year after govt introduces dedicated 3-year excise export policy

BISWAJEET BANERJEE
Lucknow, August 28

Uttar Pradesh is rapidly emerging as a major hub for alcoholic beverage exports, with liquor shipments from the state rising 84.5 per cent year-on-year after the government introduced a dedicated three-year excise export policy to make locally manufactured liquor more competitive overseas.

The growth was significantly higher than the 6.3 per cent increase in India’s overall liquor exports. Uttar Pradesh’s share in the country’s liquor exports rose from 8.1 per



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

cent to 14 per cent, moving the state from fifth to third position among exporting states, only behind Maharashtra and Punjab.

The April-June figures show that the momentum continued into the

first quarter of 2026-27. India exported alcoholic beverages worth Rs 965 crore during the period, of which Uttar Pradesh accounted for Rs 122.3 crore, or nearly 13 per cent of the national total. In vol-

ume terms, India exported around 8.13 crore litres of alcoholic beverages, while Uttar Pradesh accounted for nearly 1.05 crore litres.

The state had traditionally ranked seventh or eighth among liquor-

KEY POINTS

- » The growth was significantly higher than the 6.3% increase in India’s overall liquor exports
- » UP’s share in the country’s liquor exports rose from 8.1% to 14%
- » The state moved from 5th to 3rd position among exporting states, only behind Maharashtra and Punjab

exporting states. Its April-May exports stood at \$8.6 million, compared with \$4.66 million in the same period last year. India’s total exports rose to \$61.5 million from \$57.8 million. Uttar Pradesh’s increase of \$3.94 million was higher than India’s overall rise of \$3.65 million.

The growth followed implementation of the Uttar Pradesh Excise Export Policy 2026-29 from April 1. The government has described it as the first dedicated three-year excise export policy introduced by an Indian state. The policy aims to reduce regulatory costs

rather than provide direct financial assistance. It has abolished franchise fees on foreign liquor, beer and wine and waived brand registration fees.

For Indian-made foreign liquor and wine, the bottling fee for a 2,000-ml export bottle ranges from Rs 0.32 to Rs 4.11, against Rs 0.79 to Rs 4.11 for domestic movement. For 1,000-ml bottles, the export fee ranges from Rs 0.16 to Rs 2.05, compared with Rs 0.40 to Rs 2.05 domestically. Different slabs apply to bottles from 750 ml to 60 ml.

Similar relief has been extended to beer. For a

50-litre draught beer keg, the export fee ranges from Rs 3.10 to Rs 36.23, compared with Rs 7.55 to Rs 36.23 for domestic movement.

The policy is also attracting investments. United Breweries is setting up a unit in Unnao, while Mount Everest Breweries is establishing a facility in Hardoi. Woodpecker GreenAgri Nutrients has set up a unit in Farrukhabad.

Allied Blenders and Distillers has revived a closed unit in Moradabad, while Kian Distillery has applied to establish a beverage distillery and brewery in Gorakhpur.

EDITORIAL

Warning up front

India's long-delayed debate over front-of-pack nutrition labelling has reached a point where further hesitation would be difficult to justify. The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has now proposed prominent warnings on packaged foods and beverages containing excessive levels of sugar, salt or fat, including a red hexagonal warning for products crossing specified thresholds. The proposal follows sustained public-health pressure and sharp scrutiny from the Supreme Court over the regulator's earlier reluctance to adopt easily understood warnings. At its heart, however, the issue is remarkably simple. A consumer buying a packet of chips, biscuits, instant noodles or a sugary drink should not require nutritional expertise to understand what is inside. Information affecting health must be visible, intelligible and immediate.

India's packaged-food industry has legitimate concerns about how thresholds are determined. Serving sizes vary enormously, traditional foods cannot always be assessed through standards devised for Western diets, and regulators must ensure that classifications are scientifically sound. FSSAI is reportedly considering different assessment categories based on typical serving sizes rather than imposing an identical benchmark on every product. Such refinements deserve careful consideration. But they should improve warning labels, not become arguments against them. Nutrition tables printed on the back of packets technically disclose information, yet they often require consumers to interpret grams, percentages and recommended daily allowances while making a purchase. A clear warning performs a different function: it tells consumers, at a glance, that a product contains unusually high levels of a nutrient whose excessive consumption carries health risks.

The stakes extend well beyond consumer convenience. India is confronting an expanding burden of obesity, diabetes, cardiovascular disease and other diet-related illnesses, while processed and packaged foods have become increasingly embedded in everyday diets, including those of children. The Supreme Court has rightly emphasised the health implications for younger consumers while questioning the prolonged delay over front-of-pack warnings. Industry resistance is understandable from a commercial perspective: prominent warnings could alter buying behaviour and encourage manufacturers to reformulate products. But that is precisely why transparent labelling matters. Regulation should not decide what citizens are permitted to eat, nor should it demonise particular products. Its purpose should be to ensure that people know what they are choosing. Consumer freedom becomes meaningful only when consumers possess information they can actually understand.

FSSAI must therefore resist turning a straightforward public-health measure into another prolonged regulatory negotiation. Industry should certainly be consulted on implementation, scientific thresholds and reasonable transition periods, but commercial interests cannot enjoy a veto over the consumer's right to know. India has debated front-of-pack nutrition labelling in various forms for years; the regulator's own 2022 draft had proposed an Indian Nutrition Rating system. The present moment offers an opportunity to replace ambiguity with a simpler principle: potentially harmful nutritional excess should be impossible to hide in fine print. A warning label will not transform India's eating habits overnight, but it can make every purchase a little more informed. In public health, that small intervention can eventually produce a large dividend.

LETTER



letter2editor.mp@gmail.com.

Looming Threat

The newly formed Himalayan barrier lake is a warning India cannot ignore. Glacial instability can turn remote lakes into sudden disasters downstream. Satellite monitoring, automated sensors and real-time warning systems must become essential infrastructure across the Himalayas. Preparedness must begin before another flood exposes gaps in surveillance and response.

ANKUSH KHADELWAL, UDAIPUR

You can also send your comments to The Editor, Millennium Post, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

A Nation Under Constant Threat

Nepal's earthquakes, floods and landslides reveal how geology, climate change and vulnerable settlements are combining to create a widening regional threat

HIMALAYAN PERIL



OP SINGH

THE WRITER IS FORMER NDRF DG WHO LED INDIA'S RESCUE TEAM DURING 2015 NEPAL EARTHQUAKE

Nepal is once again racing against time. Two days after a catastrophic flash flood tore through the country's northern mountains, rescuers are digging through mud, rocks and debris in the hope of finding survivors. The disaster, triggered by a massive glacier-and-rock collapse near the Nepal-Tibet border, unleashed a torrent through the river system, sweeping away homes, roads, bridges, power infrastructure and entire stretches of human habitation. The scale of the devastation is still unfolding, with hundreds confirmed dead and many more missing.

Watching these images, I am inevitably taken back to April 2015. Then, Nepal was shaken by a magnitude 7.8 earthquake. The earth itself seemed to move beneath the feet of its people. Kathmandu and large parts of the country were devastated; villages disappeared under rubble, historic structures collapsed, and thousands lost their lives. Nearly nine thousand people were killed, and millions were affected.

I remember the extraordinary courage of ordinary Nepalis during those terrible days. But I also remember something else: how geography can turn a natural hazard into a national catastrophe. The earthquake of 2015 came



Accelerating glacier and permafrost melt is adding uncertainty to already unstable slopes

from beneath the earth. The disaster of 2026 has come from the mountains and the sky. One was a manifestation of Nepal's location in the collision zone between the Indian and Eurasian tectonic plates; the other was a frightening reminder of how rapidly the Himalayan environment is changing. Nepal is particularly exposed to earthquakes, floods and landslides, and is ranked among the world's highly vulnerable countries for both earthquakes and multiple hazards. This is what makes Nepal's pre-

PREPAREDNESS MUST NOW RACE AHEAD OF THE NEXT CATASTROPHE

dicament so extraordinary. It is not simply that the country experiences disasters. It is that several hazards converge in the same fragile landscape.

The Himalayas are young, geologically unstable mountains. Steep slopes, fragile terrain and powerful rivers create an inherent vulnerability. Now climate change is adding another layer of uncertainty. Rising temperatures are accelerating glacier and permafrost melt, potentially destabilising ice and rock formations and increasing the risk of avalanches, landslides and glacial lake outburst floods. Scientists are increasingly warning that a warmer Himalaya could mean a more volatile Himalaya.

The consequences do not stop

at Nepal's borders. The rivers descending from the Himalayas flow into India and eventually Bangladesh. A disaster in the high mountains can therefore become a flood emergency hundreds of kilometres downstream. The Gandak, Kosi, Karnali and other river systems connect the Himalayan hazard zone with densely populated plains. What begins as a landslide, glacier collapse or cloudburst in Nepal can rapidly become a humanitarian and economic problem for neighbouring countries.

That is why Nepal should not be viewed merely as a country that suffers occasional natural calamities. It is becoming a kind of natural-disaster laboratory for South Asia—where tectonic instability, fragile mountain geology, extreme rainfall, rapidly changing glaciers and expanding human settlements are converging.

But there is an important distinction between a hazard and a disaster. Earthquakes cannot be prevented; glaciers cannot be ordered to remain stable; monsoon clouds cannot be controlled. What can be changed is vulnerability.

The lesson of 2015 should therefore meet the lesson of 2026. Nepal needs to move from disaster response to disaster anticipation: dense early-warning networks, real-time river and glacier monitoring, hazard mapping, resilient infrastructure, safer settlements and trained local responders. And because the rivers and mountains do not respect political boundaries, India, Nepal, Bhutan, China and Bangladesh need far greater regional cooperation in sharing hydrological, meteorological, seismic and glacial information.

The tragedy unfolding today is therefore more than another natural disaster. It is a warning. In 2015, the earth shook beneath Nepal. In 2026, the mountains themselves appear to have moved. The message is unmistakable: South Asia's disaster geography is changing, and Nepal is at its frontline. The real question is no longer whether the next disaster will come. It is whether the region will be prepared when it does.

Views expressed are personal

Jobs in the Age of AI

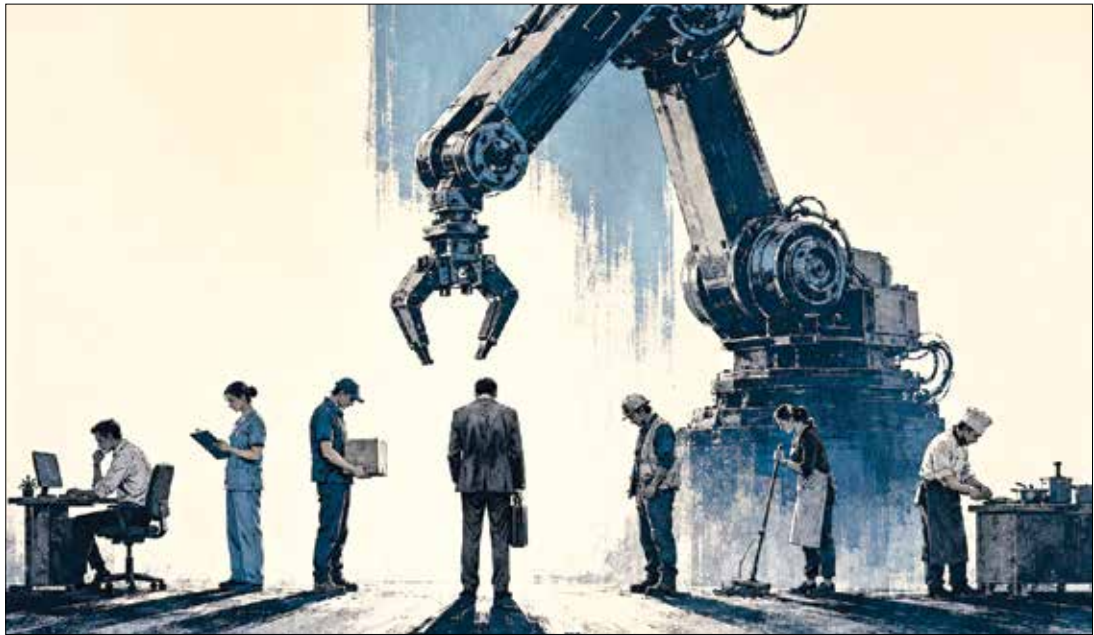
AI is eliminating jobs, creating others and fundamentally rewriting the skills equation

AT VANTAGE



SHUTAPA PAUL

THE WRITER IS AN AUTHOR AND MEDIA ENTREPRENEUR



Adaptability could become the defining currency of the AI workplace

and time again – use AI to your advantage; let it enhance your work, not remove you from it. As per the same Nomura Holdings report, AI is creating far more jobs than it is killing. So, while 31,921 people indeed lost their jobs, 83,100 AI-related jobs were also generated. Analysts believe that India is ground zero due to its back-office capabilities and will, therefore, throw up insights into the real AI impact quickly and transparently. It's a tough market for freshers, as experience is trumping rookie talent.

Across Asia, the numbers are hinting at a similar trend – 60,654 jobs lost but 1,30,758 hires related to AI, with 90 per cent of new jobs

THE JOBS MAY EXIST, BUT THE REQUIRED SKILLS ARE CHANGING

related to tech and 60 per cent of job losses linked to financial services. Jobs requiring human engagement, such as construction, education, direct healthcare and manufacturing, are witnessing the least automation. India, China and the Philippines are showing similar initial findings. A Bank of Korea report showed that

2,11,000 entry-level jobs vanished, while employment increased by 2,09,000 jobs for 50-year-olds. While assuming any of it to be set in stone in today's vastly dynamic and fragmented environment would be foolish, here's what we can confidently say – every disruption will separate the wheat from the chaff. What's redundant will eventually be on its way out – an upheaval like the one caused by AI is doing the same, only at a faster pace.

Companies are also becoming more mindful of whom they are hiring. A recent news story by Reuters said that global companies are becoming more selective with their GCC (global capability

centres) hiring. It's not that they won't hire; they are more intentional about whom they employ. They want the "right talent" with the correct mix of tech know-how, experience and adaptability. The hiring trends across GCCs in India once again hold valuable information that can shape future predictions for the job market. And why not? India is set to have 2,117 GCCs by the end of this financial year. As per a NASSCOM-Zinnov report, these GCCs are set to create 2.36 million jobs and generate a whopping USD 100 billion in revenue. The quest for the right fit has slowed hiring, and even though jobs exist, newbies will find it difficult to land them. A NASSCOM-Indeed study holds some actionable takeaways – 40 per cent of employers are looking for proven AI skills or certifications over degrees, while 32 per cent give importance to all of them.

Look, any kind of structural shift is bound to upend lives. Instead of blaming AI and creating an apocalyptic atmosphere, we humans can make a difference. Yes, jobs will be lost, but more will be created. The gap that exists now is one of skills. Corporations, educational institutions and governments can bridge that gap to ensure that graduates are trained to be job-ready in today's world. China is already doing that and showcasing a strong demand for highly skilled graduates. Remember, it's not the atom bomb that was to blame for causing devastation; it was the human hand that triggered it.

Views expressed are personal

The UN's maritime agency said Friday that 19 seafarers have been killed and at least 6,000 remain stranded on hundreds of ships unable to leave the region since the start of the Iran war on February 28.

ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Celphy India/ Santosh Kumar Joshi, Represented By Proprietor Santosh Kumar Joshi, 203, Plot No. 14, Kaushambi, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, Ghaziabad-201010, 071805003365	Flat No. 401 TF, 3rd Floor, Block-05, Authority MIG Flats, Near Plumieria Garden Estate, Sector Omicron-3, Noida, Greater Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Gautam Buddha Nagar- 201310	16/07/2026 Rs. 16,22,289,42/-	22-06-2026
2.	Hailp Loan Services India Private Limited/ Dheeraj Lahiri, Rabi Lahiri, Janki Lahiri, Represented By Directors Dheeraj Lahiri & Rabi Lahiri, House No.10, Second Floor, Rajouri Garden, Delhi-110027, 114505002815	House No. 9/93, Ground Floor, Block- 9, Maajanki Niwaas, Near Hotel Surya Grand Subhash Nagar, West Delhi Delhi- 110027	16/07/2026 Rs. 24,43,832,02/-	28-06-2026
3.	Brijesh Trading Company/ Gulab Devi, Kamla Devi, Shantilal, Narpat Singh, Represented By Partners Gulab Devi, Kamla Devi & Shantilal, 9/1612, Behind Mtnl Office, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi, Delhi- 110031, 112605000483	Property No. 9/1612, With Roof & Construction Rights Upto Last Storey, Plot No. 235, Old MPL No. 512, Out of Kharsa No.636/613/2/1, And 639/555/2/1, Situated At Abadi Gandhi Nagar, Behind State Bank of India, In The Area Village Seelampur, Illaga Shahdara, Delhi- 110031	16/07/2026 Rs. 65,96,390,04/-	28-06-2026
4.	Gae Impex Private Limited/ Alok Gupta, Ekta Gupta, Represented By Director/s Alok Gupta & Ekta Gupta, Room No. 401 & 402, 3rd Floor, A-112, Group Industrial Area, Wazirpur, Delhi- 110052, 723551000001	Entire Built-up Second Floor (Without Roof/ Terrace Rights) Being The Part of Property Between Residential Plot No. 5A, Area Measuring 218.00 Sq. Yds In Block-11, Along With One- Fourth Undivided Share In The Stilt With The Right of Parking Car Etc., (Property Known As 11/5A), Situated In The Layout Plan of Roshanara Extension Scheme, Subzimidani, Shakti Nagar, Delhi- 110007	16/07/2026 Rs. 1,26,04,004,88/-	09-06-2026
5.	Manoj Metal/ Manoj Dhingra, Shilpi Dhingra, Represented By Proprietor Manoj Dhingra, 2439/ 3 Gali Mundewali, Sadar Bara, Delhi- 110006, 135605501070	Private Shop No.5, Ground Floor Property Municipal No.2284, Situated At Baghichi Raghunath Sadar Thana Road, Gali Mundewal Area Delhi- 110006, Ad Measuring An Area Is 9.75 Sq. Mtrs. Address- 2: Private Shop No.4, Ground Floor Property Municipal No.2284, Situated At Baghichi Raghunath Sadar Thana Road, Gali Mundewal Delhi- 110006, Ad Measuring An Area Is 9.20 Sq. Mtrs. Address- 3: Address- 1: Private Shop No.1, 2284 Ground Floor Property Municipal No. 2284, Situated At Baghichi Raghunath Sadar Thana Road, Gali Mundewal Delhi- 110006, Admeasuring An Area Is 15.89 Sq. Mtrs.	27/07/2026 Rs. 71,83,443,06/-	25-06-2026
6.	Chhabra Sales/ Varun Chhabra, Represented By Proprietor Varun Chhabra, 1st Floor, 10625, NABI KARIM, Jhandewalan Road, Paharganj, Delhi- 110055, 135605001273	Property No. 10625, One Shop on First Floor Extreme Left Rear Side Portion Without Roof Rights, NABI KARIM Jhandewalan Road Paharganj Delhi- 110055	27/07/2026 Rs. 70,99,254,23/-	22-06-2026
7.	Industrial Security & Management Services/ Kushal Kumar Tripathi, Sudesh Sharma, Pushpa Tripathi, Pankaj Tripathi, Represented By Partner/s Kushal Kumar Tripathi & Brj Bhushan Sharma, Office No. 655, Sector 37 Noida Gautam Budha Nagar, Noida Gautam Budha Nagar- 201301, 157805006563	Flat No.17, Ground Floor, Tower-F, Oxford Square Supertech Eco Village-3, Sector-16B, Situated At Plot No. Plot No. GH-06 Apartment Greater Noida Gautam Budha Nagar- 201306 Uttar Pradesh, Ad Measuring An Area Is 1145 Sq Feet. With One Open Car Parking, Address- 2: Flat No.18, Ground Floor, Tower-F, Oxford Square Supertech Eco Village-3, Sector-16B, Situated At Plot No. Plot No. GH-06 Apartment Greater Noida Gautam Budha Nagar- 201306 Uttar Pradesh, Ad Measuring An Area Is 1145 Sq Feet. With One Open Car Parking.	27/07/2026 Rs. 2,04.15, 963.68/-	11-06-2026
8.	Industrial Security & Management Services/ Kushal Kumar Tripathi, Sudesh Sharma, Pushpa Tripathi, Pankaj Tripathi, Represented By Partner/s Kushal Kumar Tripathi & Brj Bhushan Sharma, office No 655, Sector 37 Noida Gautam Budha Nagar, Noida Gautam Budha Nagar- 201301, 603090054013	Flat No.17, Ground Floor, Tower-F, Oxford Square Supertech Eco Village-3, Sector-16B, Situated At Plot No. Plot No. GH-06 Apartment Greater Noida Gautam Budha Nagar- 201306 Uttar Pradesh, Ad Measuring An Area Is 1145 Sq Feet. With One Open Car Parking, Address- 2: Flat No-18, Ground Floor, Tower-F, Oxford Square Supertech Eco Village-3, Sector-16B, Situated At Plot No. Plot No.GH-06 Apartment Greater Noida Gautam Budha Nagar- 201306 Uttar Pradesh, Admeasuring An Area Is 1145 Sq Feet. With One Open Car Parking.	27/07/2026 Rs. 30.50, 717.34/-	11-06-2026
9.	Vyora Herbals Private Limited/ Represented By Directors Binil Kumar Jha & Vikash Jha, Sangita Jha, M/s. S S Fabrication (Authorized Signatory Binil Kumar Jha), A/c No. 603090047301, House No. 5, Sector-13, Amit Apts Rohini, New Delhi- 110085	Plot No 87 & 104, Part of Kharsa No. 149/11 & 149/1, P.H. No 13, Bartori- Tilda Industrial Area, Village Bartori, Tehsil & District Raipur, Chhattisgarh, Free Hold Hig Flat No. 5, Ground Floor, Amit Co-operative Group Housing Society Ltd. Presently Known As Amit Apartments, Category: (E) Society Flats, Colony Sr No. 1504, Plot No.32, Rohini Sector-13, Delhi- 110085, (Plinth Area 96 Sq Mtrs.)	01/08/2026 Rs. 56,79,453,87/-	04-04-2026

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower/s and/or guarantor/s (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payments within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: August 29, 2026

Place: Delhi/ NCR

Sincerely Authorised Officer,

For ICICI Bank Ltd.

News at a glance

Indian Bank eyes ₹1,500 cr treasury income in FY27

CHENNAI: Indian Bank expects treasury income of Rs 1,000-1,500 crore in the current financial year after earning Rs 500 crore in June quarter against an estimate of Rs 300 crore, MD and CEO Binod Kumar said.

The lender aims to lower gross NPAs to 1.5-1.6 per cent and net NPAs to 0.15-0.2 per cent, while selling Rs 200 crore in bad loans to an ARC.

Its gold loan book, currently around Rs 1.25 lakh crore, is expected to cross Rs 1.5 lakh crore, with the segment projected to grow about 20 per cent. RAM loans account for 65 per cent of its loan book.

DRI searches plant owned by Waaree Energies’ subsidiary

NEW DELHI: The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence conducted a search at the manufacturing plant of Sangam Solar One Pvt Ltd, an arm of Waaree Energies, at Unn village in Navsari, Gujarat. The search on Thursday was related to classification of stainless-steel pipes & tubes imported under EPCG Scheme & applicability of Anti-Dumping Duty.

The company has deposited the ADD amount of Rs 2,33,82,930, along with applicable interest. Separately, Waaree Energies secured a SECI order for a 700 MW solar and 700 MW/2,800 MW ESS project at Solapur, Maharashtra, through WFEPL.

RBL Bank gets GST demand notice of ₹103.76 crore

NEW DELHI: RBL Bank on Friday said tax authorities have issued a show cause notice proposing a GST demand of Rs 103.76 crore, including interest and penalty, for FY21. The notice relates to input tax credit availed under a separate GST registration for its digital banking business.

The bank said it will respond within the prescribed timelines and has adequate grounds to contest the matter, citing favourable orders on an identical issue for FY19 and FY20. It does not currently expect any material adverse impact on its operations or financial position.

India’s tyre exports rise 16% in June qtr to ₹7,700 cr: ATMA

NEW DELHI: Tyre exports from India grew 16 per cent year-on-year to Rs 7,700 crore in the June quarter despite geopolitical uncertainty, supply-chain disruptions and elevated input and logistics costs, the Automotive Tyre Manufacturers’ Association (ATMA) said.

The growth builds on a record export value of Rs 27,312 crore in FY26. Passenger Car Radial tyres saw exports rise 21 per cent in value. Exports to Europe rose 25 per cent to Rs 3,003 crore, accounting for about 40 per cent of total exports, while the US remained the largest single destination with a 16 per cent share. Indian tyres are exported to over 170 countries.

THE GOVT HAS RAISED ₹55,757 CRORE SO FAR THIS FISCAL
Govt meets 78% of FY27 divestment, asset monetisation target till August

The government sold minority stake sale in 9 PSUs, including the big ticket ones like Life Insurance Corporation (LIC) and Coal India

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

The government has achieved about 78 per cent of the FY27 budgeted disinvestment and asset monetisation target of Rs 80,000 crore within 5 months of the financial year.

The government has raised Rs 55,757 crore so far this fiscal through minority stake sale in 9 PSUs, including the big ticket ones like LIC and Coal India, as well as strategic sale of Indian Medicines Pharmaceuticals Corporation Ltd and remittances from SUUTI.

More than half of the disinvestment proceeds came from the 6.5 per cent stake sale in Life Insurance Corp (LIC) which garnered Rs 31,515 crore.

Further, a 2 per cent share sale in Coal India fetched about Rs 5,542 crore, while a 6.01 per cent stake dilution in NHPC fetched Rs 4,357 crore to the exchequer.

Earlier this week, the government sold 6 per cent stake in Hindustan Copper



MORE THAN HALF OF THE DISINVESTMENT PROCEEDS CAME FROM THE 6.5 PER CENT STAKE SALE IN LIFE INSURANCE CORP (LIC) WHICH GARNERED RS 31,515 CRORE

KEY POINTS

- » Further, a 2 per cent share sale in Coal India fetched about Rs 5,542 crore, while a 6.01 per cent stake dilution in NHPC fetched Rs 4,357 crore to the exchequer
- » The other entities in which the government disinvested its stake are Central Bank of India, NLC India, GIC, IRFC, Cochin Shipyard and Hindustan Copper
- » Earlier this week, the government sold 6 per cent stake in Hindustan Copper to raise Rs 3,041 crore. Besides, Rs 6,367 crore was raised by way of asset monetisation via InvIT

to raise Rs 3,041 crore.

The other entities in which the government disinvested its stake are Central Bank of India, NLC India, GIC, IRFC, Cochin Shipyard and Hindustan Copper.

Besides, Rs 6,367 crore was raised by way of asset monetisation via InvIT.

Taken together, the

capital receipts by way of disinvestment and asset monetisation so far this fiscal stand at Rs 62,124 crore, which is about 78 per cent of the full year budget target.

A strategic sale in IDBI Bank is on the table. After a failed attempt earlier this year to sell it, the government has received revised

bids from Dubai-based Emirates NDB and Prem Watsa-led Fairfax Financial Holdings.

The government pushing the pedal on miscellaneous capital receipts or disinvestment and asset monetisation in the current fiscal comes amid concerns over expenditure exceeding the budget esti-

mates due to higher energy and fertiliser import bills.

The government has set a 4.3 per cent fiscal deficit target for FY27.

DISINVESTMENT TARGET HISTORICALLY: Fixing separate disinvestment targets has been discontinued since the Revised Estimate (RE) of FY 2023-24.

However, Rs 30,000 crore, Rs 33,000 crore, Rs 33,837 crore and Rs 80,000 crore were budgeted under Miscellaneous Capital Receipts for RE 2023-24, RE 2024-25, RE 2025-26 and BE 2026-27, respectively.

In 2021-22 and 2022-23, as against the RE of Rs 78,000 crore and Rs 50,000 crore set in the Budget, the government had actually raised Rs 13,534 crore and Rs 35,294 crore, respectively.

In 2019-20 and 2020-21 as against the RE of Rs 65,000 crore and Rs 32,000 crore, the actual realisation was at Rs 50,300 crore and Rs 32,886 crore, respectively.

Industrial output slows to 6.7% in July on contraction in mining

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

Industrial output increased by 6.7 per cent in July from 8.8 per cent in the preceding month, mainly due to a contraction in the mining sector.

This is the fourth monthly Index of Industrial Production (IIP) data under the new series.

“In July 2026, the Index of Industrial Production recorded a 6.7 per cent year-on-year growth, supported by 7.3 per cent growth in the manufacturing sector and strong growth of 8.7 per cent in the Electricity and Gas Supply sector,” the National Statistics Office said in a release on Friday.

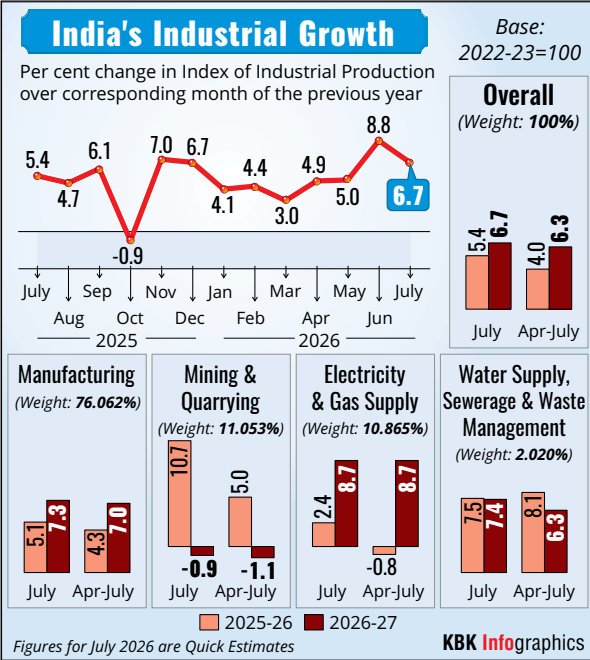
The data showed that the mining and quarrying contracted by 0.9 per cent in July against 10.7 per cent growth a year ago.

The IIP Growth in July 2025 was 5.4 per cent.

The industrial growth rate for July 2026 is 6.7 per cent against 8.8 per cent in the year-ago month, the release said.

The revised estimate of IIP for June is 8.8 per cent (from the earlier released provisional estimate of 7.3 per cent).

The growth rates of the sectors, mining & quarrying, manufacturing, electricity & gas supply and water supply, sewerage



& waste management for July 2026 are (-) 0.9 per cent, 7.3 per cent, 8.7 per cent and 7.4 per cent, respectively.

In the manufacturing sector, 19 out of 23 industry groups have recorded a positive year-on-year growth in July 2026.

The top three positive contributors for July 2026 are: 'Manufacture of motor vehicles, trailers and semi-trailers' (22.2 per cent), 'Manufacture of electrical equipment' (28.3 per cent), and 'Manufacture of machinery and equipment' (12.1 per cent).

In the industry group 'Manufacture of motor vehicles, trailers and semi-trailers', item groups 'Auto Components, Spares and Accessories', 'Passenger Cars', and 'Commercial Vehicles' have shown significant contribution to growth.

In the industry group 'Manufacture of electrical equipment', item groups 'Electrical Apparatus for Switching or Protecting Electrical Circuits, UPS and Solid-State Drives, and 'End-Face Connectors for Optical Fibres and Cables' have shown significant contribution to growth.

AMFI re-elects Sundeep Sikka as Chairman, Vishal Kapoor as Vice Chairman



Sundeep Sikka, MD & CEO of Nippon Life India Asset Management Ltd
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 28

The Association of Mutual Funds in India (AMFI) on Friday announced the re-election of Sundeep Sikka, Managing Director and CEO of Nippon Life India Asset Management Ltd, as its Chairman and Vishal Kapoor, CEO of Bandhan AMC, as Vice Chairman.

The leadership team was unanimously re-elected by the Board of Directors following AMFI's Annual General Meeting, the industry body said in a statement.

Sikka and Kapoor will continue to lead AMFI's efforts towards the strategic growth of the country's mutual fund industry, strengthening investor trust and promoting financial inclusion across India.

India’s PE investments may reach \$28.79 billion in 2026, says report

AGENCIES
New Delhi, August 28

Private equity (PE) investments in India are projected to reach \$28.79 billion (Rs 2.50 lakh crore) across 1,288 deals in 2026, according to an IVC Association report. H1 2026 saw 109 PE exits worth Rs 60,217 crore (\$6.47 billion), while PE exits worth Rs 26,847 crore (\$2.89 billion) were recorded on another measure cited in the report.

Exit value declined 34 per cent from H1 2025, which recorded 116 exits worth Rs 91,493 crore (\$10.63 billion), and 36

PUBLIC MARKET SALES ACCOUNTED FOR LARGEST SHARE AT \$4.9 BN, DOWN 6% FROM \$5.2 BN A YEAR EARLIER

per cent from the previous half-year's 126 exits worth Rs 94,786 crore (\$10.75 billion).

Public market sales accounted for the largest share at \$4.9 billion, down 6 per cent from \$5.2 billion a year earlier. The largest exit was a Rs 7,635 crore (\$839.67 million) partial exit by Partners Group

and Kedaara Capital from Vishal Mega Mart, generating 8.89x returns. Secondary sales stood at \$677.65 million, down 51 per cent from \$1.37 billion in H1 2025, while strategic sales fell 81 per cent to \$767.53 million from \$4.02 billion.

AIF vehicles participated in 369 investments, accounting for around 57 per cent of the total. Meanwhile, 344 DPIIT-registered startups raised Rs 39,518 crore (\$4.25 billion) in PE funding. IT & ITes led sectors by investment value and volume, while Bengaluru topped cities on both metrics.

AGENCIES
New Delhi, August 28

The government has widened global market access for Indian defence manufacturers by simplifying export approvals and expanding the Open General Export Licence (OGEL) framework to cover all countries except sensitive and restricted destinations.

The Department of Defence Production has increased OGEL validity from two to three years and consolidated three existing procedures into a single framework, reducing

repetitive authorisations and compliance requirements.

Stakeholder consultation will no longer be required for exports of non-lethal defence items to most destinations.

Consultation has also been removed for exports of all items for international tenders and exhibitions.

The OGEL framework allows eligible exporters to self-generate authorisations for multiple consignments of specified defence items without separate approval for each shipment.

Its coverage has expanded from 41 countries, excluding sensitive nations and countries facing UN Security Council sanctions or arms embargoes.

The government has also introduced provisions for Indian companies with long-term contracts with foreign original equipment manufacturers (FOEMs).

OGELs may be granted for eligible items and the particular foreign OEM, with validity aligned with the underlying contract, subject to conditions.

The range of eligible items has been expanded

to include civil-end-use exports of specified parts and components of small-calibre arms and protective equipment.

The Ministry of Defence said the reforms will particularly benefit manufacturers, including MSMEs, by reducing procedural requirements and enabling faster participation in international tenders and exhibitions.

The measures come as India's defence production reached a record Rs 1.78 lakh crore, while defence exports touched Rs 38,424 crore in financial year 2025-26.

NHPC adds record 1,850 MW capacity in FY26
NHPC CMD Gupta said NHPC aims 50K MW installed capacity by 2047

MPOST BUREAU
Faridabad, August 28

NHPC hosted its 50th Annual General Meeting (AGM) on Friday through video conferencing from its Registered Office in Faridabad. Shareholders considered a proposal to declare a final dividend of Rs 0.21 per equity share for FY26, in addition to the interim dividend of Rs 1.40 per equity share paid in February 2026.

Addressing shareholders, CMD Bhupender Gupta



highlighted hydropower's growing role in India's clean energy transition, particularly for grid balancing, peaking support and energy storage. He

said NHPC aims to achieve 50,000 MW installed capacity by 2047.

NHPC recorded its highest-ever capacity addition of 1,850 MW in FY26 through commissioning of Subansiri Lower (750 MW), Parbati-II (800 MW) and Karnisar Solar (300 MW). Its consolidated installed capacity crossed 9,333 MW, with 17 projects totalling 9,204 MW under construction.

On a standalone basis, NHPC's power stations generated 23,307 MU during FY26 from 7,401 MW

installed capacity across 25 stations.

Consolidated net profit stood at Rs 4,220.46 crore, while standalone net profit was Rs 3,617.80 crore.

The company also made progress on the 1,720 MW Kamala HEP, 2,880 MW Dibang Multipurpose Project and 3,097 MW Etalin HEP. Its renewable portfolio includes the 50 MW floating solar project at West Kallada, Kerala, while the 510 MW Teesta-V Power Station in Sikkim was fully restored.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE

NBCC (India) Ltd & NHPC Ltd have entered into an MoU for the execution of NHPC's infrastructure projects on a pan-India basis. The MoU was formalised on Friday at NHPC's Corporate Office, Faridabad. The agreement was signed by Deepak Kumar, GM (Civil), NHPC and Rajeev Kumar, Chief General Manager (Engineering), NBCC, in the presence of senior officials from both organisations.

TO ENSURE SMOOTH SUPPLY, PREVENT ARTIFICIAL SCARCITY

Govt to allocate fortnightly sugar sale quota to mills from September

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, August 28

The government on Friday said retail prices of sugar have started to ease with ex-mill rates declining by around 20 per cent in the last few days and announced that it will allocate a fortnightly sale quota to mills from September to ensure smooth supply and prevent artificial scarcity.

At present, the food ministry allocates a monthly quota to mills for the sale of sugar. In an official statement, the Food Ministry said it is closely monitoring availability and prices of sugar, while asserting that there is no shortage of sweetener in India.

The ministry said it carried out physical verification of stocks in sugar mills and the exercise revealed that some mills were holding more stocks than declared in monthly returns, while some mills sold less stock than their monthly allocations.

"The Government has also observed that, in certain cases, sugar sold by



mills at the beginning of the month was being dispatched or lifted by buyers only towards the end of the month. This practice contributed to artificial scarcity in the market," the statement said.

To address this problem, the government has decided to introduce a fortnightly sugar allocation system from September, replacing the existing monthly quota system.

Under the fortnightly quota, mills will have to sell at least 40 per cent of the allocation in the first week and the remaining quantity in the succeeding week. Commenting on the benefits of the new mea-

sure, the ministry said it will help to monitor the demand and supply situation, respond quickly to changes in market conditions and prevent artificial scarcity. It can release additional stocks if required to maintain adequate market availability.

"Sugar mills have already been directed to ensure that sugar sold is dispatched from the mill within seven days of sale," the ministry said.

These two measures - fortnightly quota allocation and mandatory dispatch within seven days - would significantly improve the entire supply chain.

Bulk consumers of sugar

KEY POINTS

- » Food Ministry said it is closely monitoring sugar prices and availability, while asserting that there is no sugar shortage in India
- » Sugar mills have already been directed to ensure that sugar sold is dispatched from the mill within seven days of sale, it said

have been asked not to hold stocks in excess of their operational requirements.

Talking about the prevailing high sugar prices, the government said it has taken a series of proactive measures to ensure adequate availability of sugar and prevent artificial tightening of supplies in the domestic market.

To control prices, the Centre has recently allowed imports of 10 lakh tonnes of raw sugar by October 31. It has imposed stock holding limits on dealers, as well as bulk consumers like beverage makers. Exports were already banned a few months back.

As a result, the ex-mill

sugar prices have declined by around 20 per cent in recent days, while retail sugar prices have also started coming down.

"Given the normal transmission of changes through the supply chain, retail prices are expected to follow the downward movement in ex-mill prices shortly," the ministry said.

The food ministry noted that the downward trend in ex-mill and retail prices proves that the recent surge was primarily on account of "hoarding and speculation". The ministry said that a nationwide drive for physical verification of sugar stocks at mills was carried out, which reaffirmed the comfortable availability position.

"In several cases, sugar mills were found to be holding stocks higher than those declared in their monthly returns submitted to the Government," the statement said. The ministry asserted that there is no shortage of sugar in the country and there is no justification for panic buying or excessive stocking.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Washington, August 28

In a bid to deepen bilateral economic and financial cooperation, India and Canada have said they are looking to conclude negotiations on a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) by the end of 2026 and initiate talks on a Bilateral Investment Treaty at the earliest.

At the inaugural Economic and Financial Dialogue in Toronto on Thursday, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and Minister of Finance and National Revenue, François-Philippe Champagne of Canada agreed to support engagement between relevant authorities and stakeholders to explore opportunities relating to cross-border remittances and merchant payments.

They welcomed opportunities to broaden the use of UPI in Canada through partnerships with payment service providers, recognising that such efforts could contribute to faster, and cost-effective payments and support bilateral trade, tourism, education, and the growth of small and medium-sized enterprises in both countries, as per a



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

DISCUSSIONS ARE AIMED AT EXPANDING BILATERAL TRADE TO CAD 70 BILLION, OR AROUND RS 4.65 LAKH CRORE, BY 2030

joint statement issued after inaugural Economic and Financial Dialogue.

The dialogue builds on the commitment made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney during their meeting in New Delhi in March 2026 to strengthen bilateral economic and financial cooperation.

The two sides also reaffirmed their shared commitment to conclude negotiations for a Canada-India Comprehensive Economic Partnership

Agreement by the end of 2026.

During the dialogue, the ministers exchanged views on global macroeconomic developments and domestic policy priorities and discussed ways to strengthen economic and investment ties.

Discussions are aimed at supporting financial and commercial linkages between the two countries and advancing the leaders' shared goal of expanding bilateral trade to CAD 70 billion, or around Rs 4.65 lakh crore, by 2030.

India also expressed its readiness to initiate negotiations on a Bilateral Investment Treaty at the earliest, the joint statement said.

The ministers welcomed the growing investment relationship between the two countries and recognised the role of long-term institutional capital in strengthening bilateral economic ties.

They noted the substantial presence of Canadian pension funds and other institutional investors in India and discussed ways to facilitate greater engagement between Indian and Canadian financial institutions and institutional investors.

Briefs

Rupee rises 2 paise to 95.43/dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee rose 2 paise to settle at 95.43 against the US dollar on Friday on the back of a fall in global crude oil prices and intervention by the RBI. At the interbank forex, the rupee opened at 95.54 against the greenback and traded in the range of 95.31-95.57 during the session.

It eventually settled at 95.43, up 2 paise from its previous close.

Union Bank raises \$600 mn via bonds

NEW DELHI: State-owned Union Bank of India has raised \$600 million through bonds issued to overseas investors to fund business growth. The issue comprises \$300 million each of USD-REG S Senior Unsecured Dual Tranche Notes due 2029 (3 years) & 2031 (5 years), via its Dubai International Financial Centre branch.

The 3-year bonds carry a 5.230% coupon, while the 5-year bonds carry 5.417%, payable semiannually.

Jio leads India's telecom market, adds 2.45 million mobile users

AGENCIES
New Delhi, August 28

Reliance Jio continued to lead India's telecom subscriber market in July 2026, adding 2.45 million wireless mobile subscribers and strengthening its position in 5G fixed wireless access (FWA), according to TRAI data.

Jio's wireless mobile subscriber base rose to 506.03 million at the end of July from 503.58 million in June, an addition of 2,446,727 subscribers. India's overall wireless mobile subscriber base increased by 5.54 million to 1,287.92 million during the month.

Jio held a 39.29 per cent



share of the wireless mobile market, ahead of Bharti Airtel's 38.01 per cent. Jio's subscriber base grew 0.49 per cent month-on-month, compared with Airtel's 0.55 per cent.

In broadband, Jio had 535.12 million subscribers at the end of July, compared with Airtel's 384.23 million.

Jio's 5G FWA subscriber base rose to 9.27 million

from 9.11 million in June, adding 155,869 subscribers. Airtel's 5G FWA base stood at 3.94 million after adding 116,951 subscribers.

The total 5G FWA subscriber base stood at 13.21 million, with Jio accounting for about 70.2 per cent. Jio's UBR FWA subscriber base increased to 5.14 million from 4.93 million, adding 204,320 subscribers and registering monthly growth of 4.14 per cent.

Jio was the only telecom service provider to report UBR FWA data. Its active subscriber ratio stood at 98.82 per cent, against the all-operator average of 93.48 per cent.

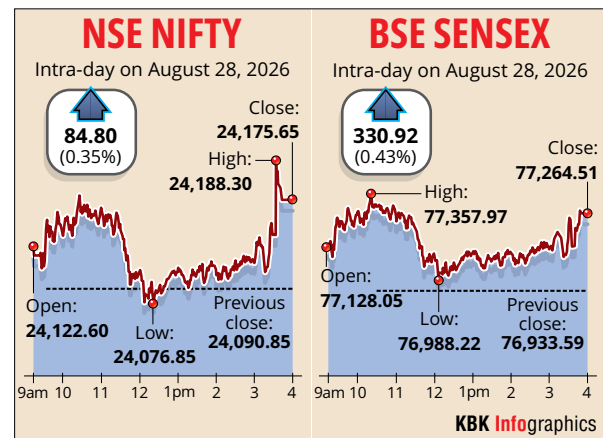
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai, August 28

Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty rebounded on Friday after two days of losses and ended higher, tracking buying in blue-chip IT stocks and a rally in global markets.

The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 330.92 points, or 0.43 per cent, to settle at 77,264.51.

The 50-share NSE Nifty settled 84.80 points, or 0.35 per cent, higher at 24,175.65.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, TCS, Infosys, Tech Mahindra, HCL Tech, Titan and Eternal were the major winners. ICICI Bank, Ultra-



Tech Cement, Asian Paints and ITC were among the laggards.

The BSE MidCap Select index climbed 0.48 per cent and the SmallCap Select

Index was marginally up by 0.02 per cent.

Among BSE sectoral indices, Focused IT surged 3.42 per cent, Information Technology jumped

3.32 per cent, PSU Bank 1.25 per cent, Bankex 1.01 per cent, MidSmall Private Banks 0.94 per cent and Metal 0.71 per cent. Insurance, Consumer Durables, Energy, Realty, Power and Oil & Gas were the laggards.

On the weekly front, the BSE benchmark declined 276.32 points, or 0.35 per cent, and the Nifty dipped 76.35 points, or 0.31 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dipped 0.17 per cent to \$89.63 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 298.26 crore on Thursday, according to exchange data.

SBI General Insurance's GDPI rises 10.9% to ₹3,506 crore in June quarter of FY27

Comprehensive Income stood at Rs 573 cr, while PAT was Rs 426 cr

MPOST BUREAU
Mumbai, August 28

SBI General Insurance continued its growth momentum in Q1 FY27, supported by a diversified portfolio, disciplined execution and a strong capital position.

Gross Direct Premium Income (GDPI) stood at Rs 3,506 crore, registering a year-on-year growth of 10.9% during the first quarter.



Naveen Chandra Jha, MD & CEO, SBI General

The insurer recorded strong growth across key retail and commer-

cial segments. Health grew by 49.9% and PA by 26.3%, while Engineering and Marine-Cargo grew by 95.4% and 16.8%, respectively. The performance reflects the company's focus on expanding its retail and commercial businesses and addressing evolving protection needs.

Comprehensive Income stood at Rs 573 crore, while PAT was Rs 426 crore, as per Ind AS financials.

The company reported a solvency ratio of 2.0 times and Combined Operating Ratio of 96.18% for Q1 FY27, highlighting its robust capital position. The quarter also marked a key milestone as SBI General Insurance became the first general insurer to report financial results under the newly adopted Ind AS framework, strengthening financial reporting, disclosure and governance.

Govt to buy back ₹30K cr securities on September 3

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai, August 28

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday announced the buyback of government securities worth Rs 30,000 crore on September 3.

The auction will take place on September 3, between 10:30 AM and 11:30 AM on the RBI Core Banking Solution (E-Kuber), the RBI said in a notification.

The government will buy back securities such as 7.33 per cent GS 2026, 5.74 per cent GS 2026, 8.15 per cent GS 2026, and 8.24

per cent GS 2027, the notification said. The RBI has not notified any amount for the individual securities within the aggregate ceiling of Rs 30,000 crore.

Auction for securities will be conducted using multiple price methods, the RBI said.

This comes at a time when the liquidity in the banking system is in huge surplus and the central bank has been conducting variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auctions to remove excess surplus liquidity from the system.

Forex kitty rises \$12.422 bn to all-time high of \$729.328 bn

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai, August 28

India's forex reserves jumped \$12.422 billion to a new all-time high of \$729.328 billion during the week ended August 21, the RBI said on Friday.

In the previous reporting week, the kitty had increased \$9.905 billion to \$716.907 billion.

The previous all-time high had stood at \$728.494 billion was attained during the week ended February 27 this year, right before the onset of the Middle East conflict.

For the week ended August 21, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, increased \$9.482 billion to \$591.333 billion, the central bank's data showed.

Value of gold reserves increased \$2.801 billion to \$114.218 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The special drawing rights (SDRs) were up by \$112 million at \$18.852 billion, the Reserve bank data said.

India's reserve position with the IMF was also up \$26 million to \$4.925 billion at the end of the reporting week, according to the apex bank's data.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



Patton International Ltd has been honoured with the prestigious Eaton Global Supplier Excellence Award 2026, becoming the only company from India to receive this recognition for outstanding performance in quality, delivery, innovation and operational excellence. Sanjay Budhia, MD, Patton International Ltd receiving Global Excellence Award in Cleveland with Dom Ponzio and Pete Denk of Eaton Corporation.

VIT inks pact with Columbia University, New York

VIT 1st Indian university to sign dual degree pact with Columbia University

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, August 27

VIT signed the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Columbia University (Columbia Engineering) New York, United States recently.

The MoU was signed in the presence of Binaya Srikantha Pradhan Consul General of India in New York by VIT Chancellor Dr. G. Viswanathan and Sen. Soulaymane Kachani, Dean of Academic Affairs and Global Partnerships



This historic partnership makes VIT the first Indian university to enter

into a dual degree agreement with Columbia University, opening world-

class academic pathways for engineering students on an international stage.

Emphasizing the significance of the partnership, VIT Founder and Chancellor Dr. G. Viswanathan highlighted the institution's commitment to delivering globally competitive education, describing the collaboration as a defining moment in the history of VIT: "This is a landmark agreement between VIT and Columbia University. We are proud to become the first Indian

university to establish a dual degree programme with one of the world's most prestigious institutions. This collaboration reflects VIT's unwavering commitment to providing globally competitive education and creating transformative international learning opportunities for our students."

Vice President Dr. G. V. Selvam and Director - International Relations, Dr. R. Seenivasan were also present during the occasion.

Briefs

Hockey India announces 50L award

NEW DELHI: Hockey India on Friday announced a cash award of Rs 50 lakh for the Indian women's team in recognition of their historic fifth-place finish at the FIH Hockey World Cup. Salima Tete's side sealed the milestone with a 3-1 win over World No. 5 Germany in the 5th/6th place classification match in Amstelveen on Thursday, marking India's best result at the tournament since they finished fourth at the inaugural edition in 1974. The team went through the campaign with just one defeat, holding higher-ranked sides China, England and Australia to draws and recording a 6-1 win over South Africa, before completing their run under Chief Coach Sjoerd Marijne with the win over Germany. Congratulating the team on the achievement, Hockey India President Dilip Tirkey said, "This is a historic result for Indian women's hockey. To finish fifth at a World Cup after 52 years is a testament to the hard work, resilience and fighting spirit this team has shown throughout the tournament."

Ashwin tears into Pant

NEW DELHI: Former India spinner Ravichandran Ashwin has questioned Rishabh Pant's shot selection and decision-making during the recent Test series against Sri Lanka, saying the flamboyant wicket-keeper-batter has not yet lived up to the expectations placed on him. Pant, backed by the Indian team management for the wicket-keeper's role in the two-Test rubber, finished with 168 runs, including two half-centuries. But his aggressive approach and shot selection continued to attract scrutiny, with Ashwin making it clear that he expects more from a player who has now played over 50 Tests. "My expectation from Rishabh Pant hasn't been fulfilled till now. I am very sorry. Sonal Dinusha had his strike rate up there. But the difference is high-risk options. When you have the game in your hand, these are all statements" Ashwin said on his YouTube channel.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE
Open e-tender notice no. TRD/OT/15/Ins/Sheet/26-27
E-tenders are invited from reputed contractors having proven experience, electrical license and sound financial standing supported by the valid documents for the work as per details given below :
(1) Name of work with location : Provision of insulation sheet under less clearance over line structure with OHE at SEB in DDU Division (Phase-III). (2) Approx. Cost of the work : ₹46,30,934/- (3) Earnest Money/Bid Security to be deposited : ₹92,600/- (4) Last date and time for submission of tender : Upto 21.09.2026 on 15.00 hrs. (5) Website particulars from where the details of e-tender can be obtained : www.iirps.gov.in
Sr. Divt. Elect. Engineer (TRD)/ ECR/Pl. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya PR/0825/DDU/TRD/TI/26-27/28

BECOMES FIRST INDIAN CHAMPION
Praggnanandhaa wins Grand Chess Tour title

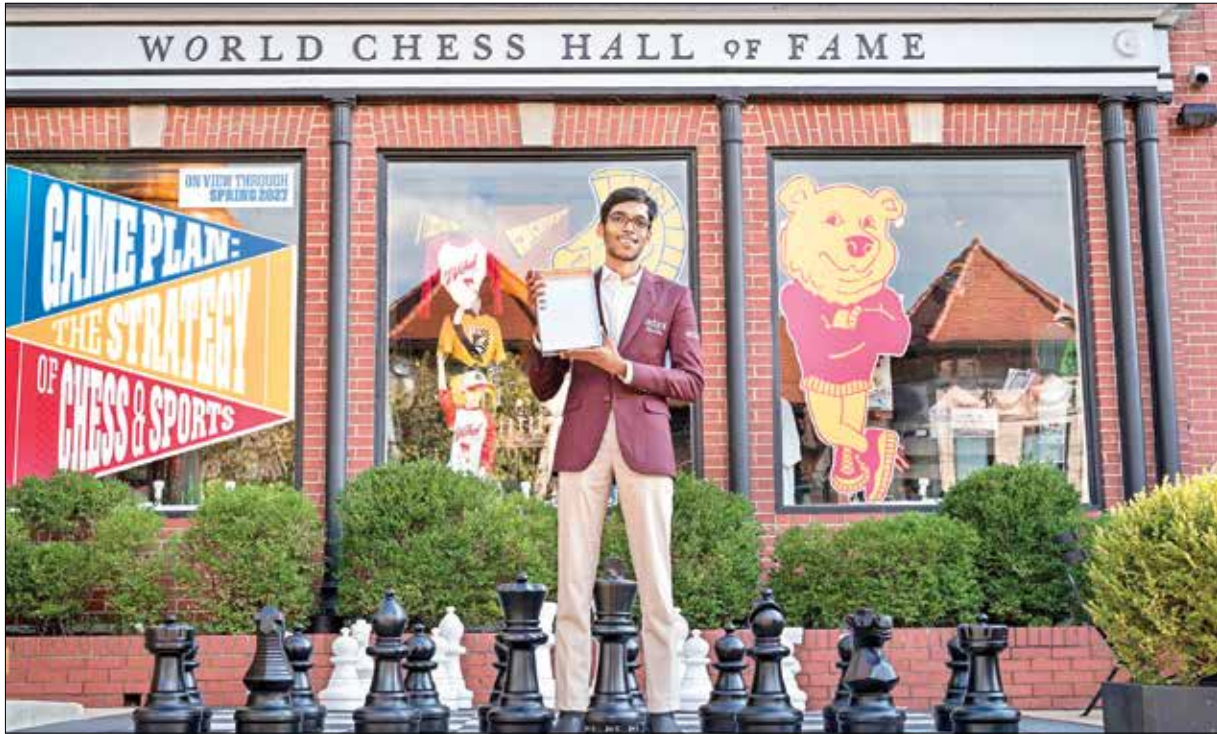
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
St. Louis, August 28

Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa became the first Indian to clinch the Grand Chess Tour title, beating Fabiano Caruana of the USA with a stunning comeback win in the grand finale here. Praggnanandhaa made a remarkable turnaround on Thursday after trailing Caruana by six points at the start of the day at the Saint Louis Chess Club here. The Indian eventually prevailed 15-13 to win his maiden GCT title and pocket USD 200,000 as the winning purse. The title win also guaranteed Praggnanandhaa a spot in the next year's Grand Chess Tour along with Caruana, and another American Wesley So, who defeated Vincent Keymer of Germany 18-12 to take the third place. "Honestly, I didn't think I had many chances today," Praggnanandhaa told 'Chess.com'. "It's not every day that you can get one win from Fabi, but to get two, it was important in the rapid."

Neeraj Chopra qualifies for Diamond League Finals
Chopra in line for WA Ultimate Championships

ASSOCIATED PRESS
New Delhi, August 28

Indian javelin throw ace Neeraj Chopra has qualified for the Diamond League Finals to be held in Brussels on September 5 despite competing in just two events of the prestigious one-day meeting series. Chopra secured 12 points after finishing second in both the Doha and Lausanne DL events on June 19 and August 21 respectively to take the sixth spot in the standings and be eligible to compete in the winner-takes-all grand finale in Brussels. The standings were updated at the end of the 14th and the last leg of the series in Zurich on Thursday. Of the 14 Diamond League meetings of the year, five featured men's javelin throw and Chopra competed in just two. The 28-year-old is on a comeback trail after recovering from a lower back injury that has troubled him since September last year. The injury delayed



Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa became the first Indian to clinch the Grand Chess Tour title in St Louis PTI

mentored by five-time world champion Viswanathan Anand, started the day six points behind, but pulled another rabbit out of the hat and took a lead of two points after winning both the rapid games (four points to winner per game). It was even-stevens in the subsequent four games of blitz, with Praggnanandhaa and Caruana winning one each while the remaining two were drawn. The two-point lead at the end of the rapid games proved decisive for the Indian Grandmaster. The first game of the blitz section was a drawn

affair before Caruana won the second to level the scores at 12-12. A determined Praggnanandhaa prevailed over his opponent in the third game to restore his two-point lead (14-12). Had Caruana won the last blitz game, he would have forced two more games with the peculiar

People don't always know the real story:
Marijne defends pre-World Cup leave

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Amstelveen, August 28

India women's hockey team chief coach Sjoerd Marijne on Friday insisted that his pre-World Cup leave did not compromise the team's preparations, asserting that he remained involved in every aspect of the build-up to the tournament in which India finished a creditable fifth.

KEY POINTS

- » Marijne's decision to take leave before the World Cup came under scrutiny in a section of the media
- » The Dutchman, however, said the team's preparation remained on track with the support of his coaching staff

Marijne's decision to take leave before the World Cup came under scrutiny in a section of the media.



Champion Rashid Khan (centre) receives his trophy and cheque from Amandeep Johl, CEO, DP World PGTI (left) and Rupinder Gill, GM, Vooty Golf County (right)

Doping cases rock Indian wrestling, WFI issues strict anti-doping advisory

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, August 28

A string of doping and whereabouts-related cases involving Indian wrestlers, including two Asian Games selections and fresh U23 national medallists, has prompted the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) to issue a stern advisory stressing that athletes must take personal responsibility for anti-doping compliance. The advisory comes after Asian Games-bound wrestlers Mukul Dahiya (86kg freestyle) and Deepanshu (130kg Greco-

Roman) were removed from India's squad following doping cases. "WFI had sought a replacement of Deepanshu with Ronak Dahiya but the federation was told that replacement was allowed only in case of an injury and not for doping violation," a WFI source told PTI. "Lack of education among wrestlers is a major issue and that's why they miss tests which they are supposed to take under whereabouts rules. That's why we have issued this advisory," added the source.

"I have seen every training, match, done meetings and had personal contact with the players, so it was not that I didn't know what was going on," Marijne told PTI in an interview after India's World Cup campaign. "People don't always know the real story and that's fine as long as we know what we have done and we covered everything."

The Dutchman, however, said the team's preparation remained on track with the support of his coaching staff.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
No.- Dy. CEE/PU/CNB/26-27/T-05R Date: 26.08.2026
TENDER NOTICE
Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer (Project), North Central Railway, Kanpur for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.
E-Tender No.: Dy. CEE/PU/CNB/26-27/T-05R | Approx Cost (Rs.): 4394004.25
Description of work: Fencing of Temporary boundary for all 25 different PSI (TSS/SP/SSP) posts (2x25kV) in VGLJ-GOY section under Mission 3000MT.
Earnest Money (Rs.): 87900.00 | Cost of Tender Form (Rs.): 00
Date of closing Tender: 16.09.2026 15:00 hrs. | Validity of Tender: 60 days
Date of completion/Period from issue acceptance letter: 04 Months
Tender on line can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs. on 16.09.2026. For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.iirps.gov.in 1933/26(K)
f North central railways www.nctr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPNCR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr.PC/84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ajay @ Titu, S/o Bansai @ Bnashi R/o H.No.116, Parvesh Nagar, Mubarakpur, Dabas, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.523/2020 u/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. K. N. Katju Marg, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ajay @ Titu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ajay @ Titu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ajay @ Titu of FIR No.523/2020 u/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. K. N. Katju Marg, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **20.11.2026**.
By Order,
Sh. Aakash Sharma
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03, North District
Room No.213, Rohini Court, Delhi
DP/11971/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON (SEE SECTION 84 BNSS)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Roop Narayan @ Hallu S/o Kamal Parsad R/o H. No. F-260, Gali No. 12, Phase-6, Aya Ngar, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 601/2024, U/s 326(G) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Fatehpur Beri, South Dist. New Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Roop Narayan @ Hallu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Roop Narayan @ Hallu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Roop Narayan @ Hallu of case FIR No. 601/2024, U/s 326(G) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Fatehpur Beri, South Dist. New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **05.10.2026**.
By Order
Ms. Richa Parihar
Ld. ASJ-05, Room No. 201
2nd Floor, Saket Court, New Delhi
DP/11959/SD/2026
(Court Matter)

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS!
SPECIAL TRAINS
For the convenience of Rail passengers, Railways have decided to run Special Trains as per the details mentioned below:-

04165/04166 Prayagraj-Shakurbasti- Prayagraj Special						2 Trips
Train No. 04165	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04166	ARR.	DEP.
---	20:00	---	Prayagraj	22:30	---	---
10:00	---	---	Shakurbasti	---	12:00	---

Days of run : 04165 Ex. Prayagraj on 29.08.2026 and 04166 Ex. Shakurbasti on 30.08.2026.
Composition: 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General.
Stoppages: Fatehpur, Kanpur, Etawah, Tundla, Aligarh & Delhi Stations

02157/02158 Rani Kamlapati- Hazrat Nizamuddin-Rani Kamlapati Special						2 Trips
Train No. 02157	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 02158	ARR.	DEP.
---	21:20	---	Rani Kamlapati	23:15	---	---
10:30	---	---	Hazrat Nizamuddin	---	12:10	---

Days of run : 02157 Ex. Rani Kamlapati on 30.08.2026 and 02158 Ex. Hazrat Nizamuddin on 31.08.2026.
Composition: 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General.
Stoppages: Vidisha, Bina, Virangana Lakshmibai Jhansi, Gwalior & Mathura Jn. Stations.

04642/04641 Amritsar-Hazur Sahib Nanded- Amritsar Reserved Special						2 Trips
Train No. 04642	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04641	ARR.	DEP.
---	20:10	---	Amritsar	11:20	---	---
11:00	---	---	Hazur Sahib Nanded	---	21:00	---

Days of run : 04642 Ex. Amritsar on 31.08.2026 and 04641 Ex. Hazur Sahib Nanded on 06.09.2026.
Composition: Sleeper & General.
Stoppages: Beas, Jalandhar City, Phagwara Jn., Ludhiana Jn., Sirhind Jn., Rajpura Jn., Ambala Cantt., Panipat Jn., Delhi Safdarjung, Mathura Jn., Agra Cantt. Jn., Gwalior Jn., Virangana Lakshmibai Jhansi Jn., Bina Jn., Bhopal Jn., Itarsi Jn., Khandwa Jn., Bhusaval Jn., Mammad Jn., Nagarsul, Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar, Jalna, Parbhani Jn. & Purna Jn. Stations.

For detailed information, please call RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit enquiry website: www.enquiry.indianrail.gov.in

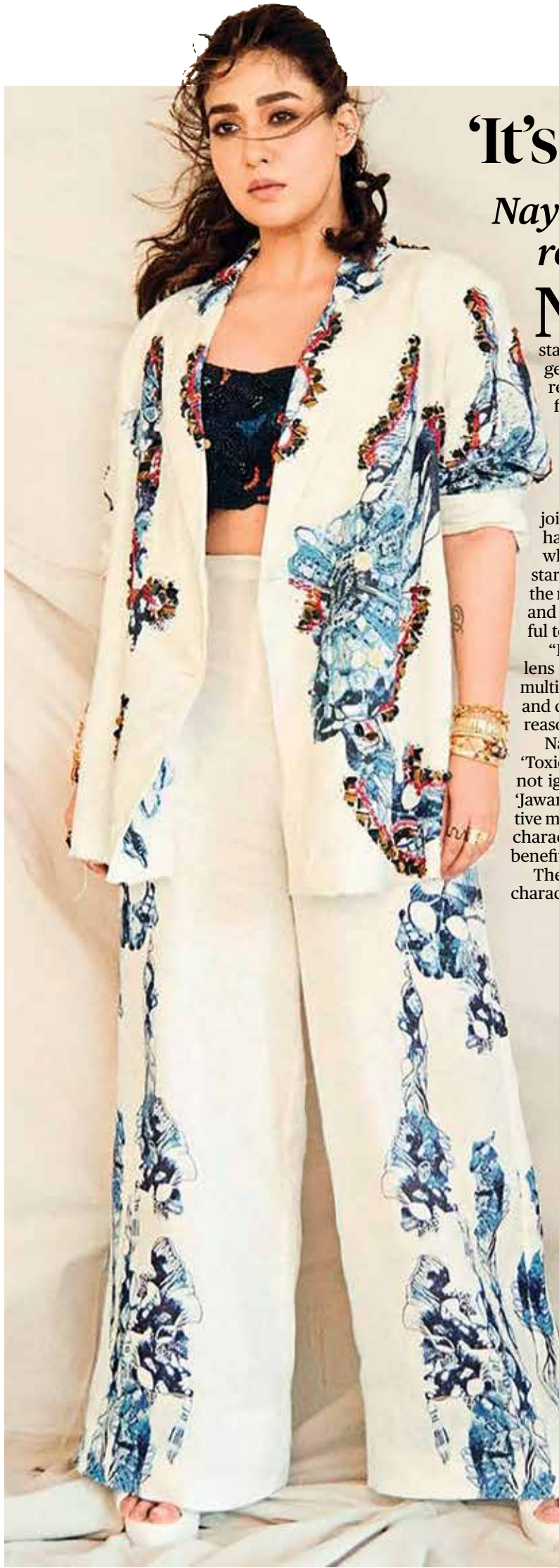
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SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE



'It's a role I couldn't ignore'

Nayanthara got candid about her short role in Yash's released film, 'Toxic'

Nayanthara was seen in the recently released film 'Toxic: A Fairy Tale for Grown-Ups', which stars Yash and Kiara Advani. The film generated massive buzz before its release but opened to a lukewarm first-day response. However, the actress, who is a part of this ensemble cast, spoke to 'Variety India' about why she gave her nod to playing Ganga in the latest film.

Speaking about her decision to join the film, Nayanthara said that she has never chosen projects based on whether they are solo films or multi-starrers. The actress stated that, for her, the most important thing is the character and whether it has something meaningful to contribute to the film's story.

"I've never looked at films through the lens of screen space or labels like solo or multi-starrer," she said, adding that a story and character that excite her are enough reasons to come on board.

Nayanthara further revealed that 'Toxic' offered her a role she simply could not ignore. Speaking about cinema, the 'Jawan' star shared that it is a collaborative medium and believes that when every character is written well, the entire film benefits.

The actress plays Ganga in the film, a character she believes has much more to



'I'VE NEVER LOOKED AT FILMS THROUGH THE LENS OF SCREEN SPACE OR LABELS LIKE SOLO OR MULTI-STARRER,' SHE SAYS

offer than what audiences may have seen in the trailer so far. According to Nayanthara, Ganga has her own voice, choices and emotional journey and influences the story rather than merely existing to support someone else's character.

AGENCIES

Alicia Vikander joins 'Enigma Variations'

The upcoming limited 'Netflix' series stars Aaron Taylor-Johnson in the lead role

Oscar winner Alicia Vikander will feature alongside Aaron Taylor-Johnson in the upcoming limited series adaptation of author Andre Aciman's novel 'Enigma Variations'.

Taylor-Johnson will play Paul, a man whose identity is shaped by a series of romantic relationships over six transformative years, while Vikander will portray Claire.

The series also stars Riley Keough as Maud, Devon Terrell as Manfred, Nicholas Podany as Harlan and Carl Clemons-Hopkins as Noah. 'Netflix' stated that Sarah Pidgeon, Peter Hermann, Juliana Canfield and Francesca Cavallin have also joined the cast.

'Enigma Variations' follows Paul through relationships and encounters across Italy, New York and New England, examining the complexities of desire and the search for lasting love. The limited series comes from 'Media Res', the production company behind shows including 'The Morning Show' and 'Pachinko'.

Amanda Kate Shuman,



TAYLOR-JOHNSON WILL PLAY PAUL, A MAN WHOSE IDENTITY IS SHAPED BY A SERIES OF ROMANTIC RELATIONSHIPS OVER SIX TRANSFORMATIVE YEARS

known for 'The Wheel of Time' and 'Carrie Soto Is Back', has written and will executive produce the series. Oliver Hermanus, whose credits include 'Living' and 'The History of Sound', will direct.

PTI

Danny Ramirez joins 'Miami Vice '85'

Actor Danny Ramirez is the latest addition to the cast of Universal Pictures' 'Miami Vice '85' film. The film is directed by Joseph Kosinski and will feature the actor alongside Michael B Jordan and Austin Butler, according to the entertainment news outlet 'Deadline'.

It explores the glamour and corruption of mid-1980s Miami in an all-new version of Miami Vice, inspired by the pilot episode of the landmark 'Universal Television' series that influenced culture and set the style of everything from fashion to filmmaking.

Ramirez's role is unknown. Produced by the filmmaker and Dylan Clark under 'Dylan Clark Productions'.

Ramirez will also feature in 'Avengers: Doomsday', where he will reprise his role as Joaquin Torres. The film is directed by Joe Russo and Anthony Russo and will also feature Robert Downey Jr, Chris Evans, Vanessa Kirby and others.

PTI



Meghna Gulzar talks about her new film 'Daayra'

Filmmaker Meghna Gulzar said her upcoming thriller 'Daayra', starring Kareena Kapoor Khan and Prithviraj Sukumaran in the lead roles, took her into unexplored creative and social territory, while allowing her to examine the shades of grey that exist within individuals and society.

Meghna, daughter of cinema icon Gulzar, shared a note on 'Instagram', saying that she has explored these shades of grey in her earlier films, including 'Talvar', 'Raazi', 'Chhapaak' and 'Sam Bahadur' but 'Daayra' turned out to be something else.

"Daayra" took my creativity to areas I have never explored before. It took my social awareness to reaches I



'DAAYRA ALLOWED ME TO EXPLORE CREATIVE, SOCIAL TERRITORY I HAD NEVER EXPLORED,' SAYS THE FILMMAKER

didn't know I had. As a student of Sociology, I learned that our life and our society are not binary. It's not just black and white. There is a spectrum of grey that we exist in. In my journey as a filmmaker, through 'Talvar', 'Raazi',

'Chhapaak' and 'Sam Bahadur', I have cherished exploring that very grey within characters and within the world they and we live in. 'Daayra' for me, not only explores that grey... It invades it... It attempts to dismantle it," she said.

The film stars Kareena as DCP Ajooni Kohli and Prithviraj as DCP Raman Kumar.

PTI

RAJKUMAR HIRANI ON CLIMAX OF 'PRITAM & PEDRO'

'Jaane Bhi Do Yaaro shaped the bittersweet climax'

Filmmaker Rajkumar Hirani said the climax of his debut OTT project 'Pritam and Pedro', where a cop and his tech-savvy partner crack a major cybercrime case only to see someone else take the credit for it, was inspired by the ending of the 1983 classic 'Jaane Bhi Do Yaaron'.

The show, directed by "Three of Us" fame Avinash Arun, features Hirani's son Vir and Arshad Warsi as the crime-solving pair. Hirani said the ending of 'Jaane Bhi Do Yaaro', where the central characters expose a scam but get no recognition, stayed with him while he was trying to find an unconventional ending for his series.

"I wanted them to be like two poor guys who solve everything, but they don't get anything. It's like 'Jaane Bhi Do Yaaro' to me. Like, those two guys, played by Naseeruddin Shah and Ravi Baswani, do everything and they don't get what they want. So, I was sure that this should be their ending," the filmmaker, who served as a creator and producer on the show, told PTI in an interview.

'Jaane Bhi Do Yaaro',



HE'S HAPPY THAT THE SHOW HAS RESONATED WITH CYBERCRIME PERSONNEL, AS MANY REACHED OUT TO HIM AFTER WATCHING THE SHOW

directed by Kundan Shah, is a satire on corruption, bureaucracy and the nexus between politicians, businessmen and the media. The film follows two struggling photographers (Shah and Baswani), who stumble upon evidence of corruption while trying to make a living.

Hirani is happy that the show has resonated with

cybercrime personnel, as many reached out to him after watching the show. "A lot of cops and cyber people also saw it and called me, saying, 'It happens daily in our department. Someone else does the work and our senior takes the credit'. In this show, the junior took it, but someone else took the credit. It happens often with us."

Released on July 3 on 'Jio Hotstar', 'Pritam Pedro' has emerged as India's most-watched web series of 2026 so far, according to a report by 'Ormax Media'. Hirani said it was deeply gratifying to know that his first outing on a streaming platform has reached its audience.

AGENCIES

AVOIDING BEING TYPECAST

'Started turning down predictable roles'

Taapsee Pannu will be next seen in Netflix's action-drama 'Gandhari'

Taapsee Pannu said she has often told filmmakers not to cast her in roles that audiences can easily predict, as she doesn't want to be trapped in a particular image. The Delhi-born actress, who charted an unconventional path in cinema with hard-hitting dramas such as 'Pink', 'Mulk', 'Thappad' and 'Assi', said she'd love to do a fun film like 'Khel Khel Mein', the 2024 comedy where she was part of an ensemble cast.

"Everybody is going into their comfort zone and using tried-and-tested methods. For instance, for glamorous roles, the industry has a set of five actresses they can cast and for hard-hitting, issue-based films, they have another set of five actresses to cast," Pannu told PTI in an interview.

She added, "I've actually started turning down films for this reason, telling makers that the audience will easily guess the ending. So, I tell them, 'Don't cast me in this; it's bad for your film'.



I've gone and 'de-sold' myself to a few films."

Pannu, who will be next seen in Netflix's action-drama 'Gandhari', said she has played strong women characters on screen and enjoyed them too, but these roles came to her at a time when conventional female lead roles were not an option.

AGENCIES

"It's a snowball effect. From the beginning of my career, I had no options in regular mainstream cliched roles, which are actually money-spinners for actresses. I didn't get those kinds of roles. Hence, I took the other type of roles and to my luck, those films and roles later became mainstream."

AGENCIES

